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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: RSS

A slate-roofed traditional house at Dharapani of Dhaulagiri Rural Municipality-7 in Magdi district.

Nepal needs financial support to deal with climate crisis: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16



Prime Minister Prachanda

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that although Nepal contributes almost zero to global emissions, it is experiencing the direct, unequal and harmful effects of climate change.

Addressing the conference on climate change and the role of parliamentarians in sustainable development here on Friday, PM Prachanda said that climate change was a big challenge for socio-economic and environmental welfare.

Mentioning that climate change is emerging as a global threat and will create a serious opportunity for development possibilities, he said that the least developed countries are more vulnerable to the effects of climate change.

"Our people have been badly affected by climatic disasters such as landslides, floods, forest fires, ice landslides and droughts," he said. "People of such countries who are at risk need financial and technical support, and the world should pay attention to that."

Pointing out the serious financial and technical gaps in the efforts to implement plans to reduce the effects of climate change, Prime Minister Prachanda said that there was a need to gather more resources to make the people flexible with the ecosystem and climate change and to plan and implement climate adaptation at the local level.

According to him, there is a need for dialogue between parliamentarians and policymakers around the world to advocate for climate justice and protect the sustainable future of the ecosystem, people and the earth. The damage and loss fund should be implemented smoothly, he said.

Prime Minister Prachanda said, "I want the developed countries to fulfil the climate finance obligation of US$ 100 billion, speed up climate actions through the Green Climate Fund and expand access to the Least Developed Countries (LDCs) and emphasise its implementation."

As the president of an LDC, PM Prachanda also urged developed economies and the international community to help countries that are at risk of climate change.

He said that Nepal is fully committed to securing clean energy and maintaining 45 per cent of the land covered by forests. "Nepal is fully committed to the Paris Agreement. We are committed to achieving zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2045," he said.

MINISTER JWALA INSPECTS POSTAL HIGHWAY IN BANKE

BY GOVINDA SHARMA
Banke, Feb. 16

Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala has said that the government will not compromise the quality and timely completion of development projects.

Speaking at an interaction programme held at Khajura in Bnake district on Friday, after inspecting the Nepalgunj-Gulariya road section under the Postal Road, Minister Jwala said, "We have taken action against the contractors who do not accomplish projects in time, and the employees who neglect their duties."

Minister Jwala said that the Ministry had given special emphasis on completing quality development projects within the stipulated time.

Stating that budget management was the responsibility of the government, he said that the construction entrepreneurs should focus on completing work within the deadline.

He said a policy had been adopted to honour the construction entrepreneurs who do quality work within the stipulated time.

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Budget ceiling of Rs. 1,800 bn recommended for next FY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

A budget ceiling of Rs. 1,800 billion has been set for the upcoming fiscal year 2024/25, said Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat.

Speaking at a press conference organised to inform about the budget and other contemporary issues at the ministry on Friday, Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said that the National Planning Commission has recommended a budget ceiling of Rs. 1,800 billion for the next fiscal year.

The resources assessment committee formed under the chairmanship of the Vice Chairman of the National Planning Commission has set a budget limit of Rs 1,800 billion, he said.

The Secretary of the Ministry of Finance is also a member of the assessment committee.

Finance Minister Dr. said that while fixing the ceiling, there were constant discussions among the concerned agencies, including the NPC and the Ministry of Finance and there was no dispute.

"Discussions are held from different angles, including the availability of resources and demands. There is no dispute among the institutions, including NPC and the Ministry of Finance regarding the issues," he said.



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat speaking to media persons at a press meet organised in the Ministry on Friday.

He said that the ministry would prepare the budget being realistic based on the resources and priorities and budget ceiling.

The Ministry of Finance will allocate the budget based on priorities and implementation conditions, he said, adding that the Ministry would not allocate the budget haphazardly creating additional financial burden for a long time.

Stating that the informal economy is still high, Minister Dr. Mahat said that the budget of the next fiscal year would focus on formalising the informal economy and expanding the tax nets instead of tax rates.

He said that homework had been started by forming a committee to bring the informal sector under the scope of taxation.

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Report on Balkumari incident submitted to DPM Shrestha

Minister Jwala blamed for incident

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

The Commission formed by the government to investigate the truth about the Bal Kumari incident has submitted its report to Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha.

After accepting the report at the Ministry on Friday evening, Deputy Prime Minister Shrestha said that the commission's investigation, facts and the conclusions drawn diligently would be implemented soon.

Birendra Shah of Chowrapati, Achham and Sujan Rawat of Mahabu, Dailekh were killed in a protest at the EPS Korea branch office at Balkumari, Lalitpur, on December 29 last year.

The Cabinet had formed the Commission under former High Court Judge Shekhar Prasad Paudel on January 1, 2024 to investigate the incident and submit the report with opinions, suggestions and recommendations within one month.

Former Additional Inspector General of Nepal Police Arun Kumar BC and Home Ministry Spokesperson and Joint Secretary Narayan Prasad Bhattarai were members of the commission chaired by Paudel.

The Commission started work on January 4 and submitted the report in 44 days. The deadline of the Commission was extended by 15 days.

A statement issued by Paudel, the chairman of the Commission, stated that the Commission inspected the scenes of the incident, documented the statements of 16 people including eyewitnesses, media coverage and persons, families of the victims, injured of the incident, expert doctors and other people related to the incident, and 29 people including officials of the security agencies related to the incident and others.

Similarly, it has been said that the reports and statements were taken from the EPS Korea Branch Balkumari, District Administration Office Lalitpur, District Police Range, Lalitpur, Armed Police Force, Nepal No. 21 Battalion,

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Postage stamps printed within country after 64 years

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 16



The government has been able to print postage stamps within country after 64 years. Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, affixed the first day cancellation mark on 11 types of postage stamps. The stamps were printed at Janak Education Materials Centre.

The Department of Postal Service published the postage stamps bearing the images of martyr Rambriksha Yadav, leftist leader Sahana Pradhan, literary figure Netra Lal Paudel, democratic fighter Kami Budha, Shreebala Tripurasundari Devi Temple, five medicinal herbs including 'marethi', and silver jubilee of Nai Publication.

Department's Director General Pradip Adhikari informed that it printed 8 million copies of postage stamps showing national figures, medicinal herbs and religious shrines. Earlier, the postage stamps were printed in various countries as India, Indonesia and Latvia.

Minister Sharma observed that stamps would contribute to inform present generation about the significant people, places and things of the country.

Similarly, former minister Dinanath Sharma observed that government had done well by printing the postal stamps on the people playing significant roles in various political movements for the change in country.

Former minister Ram Kumari Jhankri viewed the present generation could learn from the contribution made by the previous generation to ensure federal republic in Nepal.

Brazil's health agents scour junkyards and roofs for mosquitos to fight dengue epidemic

AP
Rio De Janeiro, Feb. 16

The small team of state public health workers slalomed between auto parts strewn across a Rio de Janeiro junkyard, looking for standing water where mosquitoes might have laid their eggs.

They were part of nationwide efforts to curtail a surge in Brazil of the mosquito-borne illness of dengue fever during the country's key tourist season that runs through the end of February.

Paulo Cesar Gomes, a 56-year-old entomologist, found some mosquito larvae swimming in shallow rainwater inside a car bumper.

"We call this type of location a strategic point" because of the high turnover in items converging from all over, he said. "It's difficult not to have mosquitoes here."

Earlier in the month, just days before Rio kicked of its world-famous Carnival festivities, the city joined several states and the country's capital in declaring a public health epidemic over this year's greater-than-normal number of cases of dengue.



"We had more cases in January than any other January," Ethel Maciel, head of health surveillance at Brazil's Health Ministry, said in an interview with The Associated Press.

So far this year, Brazil has recorded 512,000 cases nationwide, including both confirmed and likely cases — nearly four times more than those registered in the same period a year ago.

There have been 425 deaths under investigation for dengue so far this year, with 75 confirmed, as compared with just over 1,000 for all of 2023.

Dengue is a viral infection transmitted to humans through the bite of infected mosquitoes. Frequent rains and high temperatures, which accelerate the hatching of mosquito eggs and the development of larvae, make the famously hot city of Rio especially susceptible to outbreaks.

Many who are infected never develop symptoms, but dengue can cause high fever, headache, body aches, nausea and a rash, according to the World Health Organization. While most get better after a week or so, some develop a severe form that requires hospitalization and can be fatal.

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President Paudel stresses economic prosperity

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Feb. 16

President Ramchandra Paudel has said that economic prosperity, development and peace are the needs of the country.

While inaugurating the Mega Kavrepalanchowk Festival 2080 held in Banepa on Friday, President Paudel said that after the political changes, the country needed economic prosperity and urged the policymakers, planners and the government to come up with special programmes to reduce imports and increase exports by increasing production and creating jobs in the country.

He said that an economically prosperous Nepal could be built by paving the way for industrialisation in the country through the development of agriculture, tourism, water resources and industry. "In addition to agriculture and animal husbandry, it is necessary to protect the indigenous techniques, crops and practices and transform them to the new generation," he added.

President Paudel said, "It is also necessary to pay equal attention to public awareness about original products with nutritional value that have been overshadowed by the effects of increasing urbanisation."

In a country with diverse geographical structures, the production of wheat, rice and sugarcane in the plains and high-value fruits such as tea, oranges, coffee, olives, kiwi, dragon fruit, and avocados in the mountainous areas and apple and walnut cultivation in the highlands and mountains will support the balanced development of the agricultural sector, he said.

President Paudel said that there was a need to use information technology to inform farmers all over the country about market conditions, diseases, pests and weather through mobile phones. He said that in the recently published fourth edition of the Nepal Standards Living Survey, 5.9 million people are under the poverty line, so there is a need for extensive policy reforms in the agricultural sector to free people from poverty.

"It seems that the policymakers, government and professional organisations should pay special attention to creating an environment that attracts youths who have returned from abroad to use the skills they have learned in agriculture," President Paudel said. He said that the state should give priority to the provision of marketing of farmers' products, timely supply of fertilisers and availability of the latest inputs and technologies.

The President said that the government should give priority to the provision of identification and diagnosis of farmers' problems, provision of respect for labour to raise the morale of farmers, concessional loans to farmers and provision of agricultural insurance.

He said that there should be no delay in ending the traditional agricultural system and moving towards industrialisation through the latest high-tech technology, equipment, quality seeds and the highest practice of professionalism.

On the occasion, Chief Minister of Bagmati Province Shalikram Jamkattel said that the provincial government was working with the agriculture sector as the priority.

He said that in the first phase, the provincial government was going to start a community-based one-ward-one agricultural production programme in 85 locations within the province. He said that the provincial government has also advanced irrigation programmes of strategic importance.

Lawmaker Gokul Prasad Baskota said that although there is plenty of arable land in the district, there was a problem with irrigation, so the government should pay attention to it. He said that determining the quota of chemical fertilisers brought by the provincial government was not scientific.

Chief of the District Coordination Committee Deepak Kumar Gautam said that the mega agricultural festival held in Banepa would help in marketing the agricultural products of the farmers.

Meanwhile, six farmers of Kavrepalanchok and Sindhupalchok districts were awarded the 'President's Best Farmer Award' for their significant contribution to the field of agriculture through the operation of agri-business. They were felicitated with the award from President Paudel.

President Paudel honoured Rajendra Thapa of Panauti Municipality-3 of Kavre, who has been involved in the agricultural profession for a long time, Badri Prasad Dhungana of Panchkhaal Municipality-12 and Rupesh Pakhrin of Bethanchok Rural Municipality who have been engaged in animal husbandry.

Likewise, Deepak Kumar Lamichhane of Helambu Rural Municipality-4 who produces trout fish in Sindhupalchok, Rajkumar Dhakal of Melamchi Municipality-11 who produces grass, and Binod Pradhan of Bhotekoshi Rural Municipality-1 who raises goats, were also honoured with the award. Each of them were honoured with Rs. 10,000 cash, shawls and certificates



PHOTO: KEDAR TIMALSINA/TRN
President Ramchandra Paudel inaugurating the Mega Kavrepalanchowk Festival 2080 held in Banepa on Friday.

85% WORK OF LIPING KHOLA HYDRO PROJECT COMPLETED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sindhupalchowk, Feb. 16

About 85 per cent of works on the 16.26 MW Liping Khola Hydropower Project have been completed. The construction of the project, promoted by Him River Hydropower Company Limited, has reached its final stage.

Eighty-five per cent of the works on the tunnel, dam, pipeline and powerhouse have been completed. Executive director of the project Sudeep Kumar Chaudhary said that within two years of the construction began, the project had reached its final stage.

He said that power generation from the project would start in mid-June 2024 if the construction work moved ahead at the present speed. Chaudhury said that if the project-affected residents of Bhotekoshi kept on supporting them, the production would begin at the specified time.

Similarly, the construction of the transmission line has also been targeted to be completed by mid-May this year. According to him, 16.26 megawatts of electricity from the project will be connected to the national transmission line from the beginning of the upcoming Nepali New Year.

It is estimated that the electricity production of the project may decrease by 30 per cent in the winter months. The electricity generated by the Liping Khola project will be connected to the transmission line of the 102 MW Madhya Bhotekoshi Hydropower Project and will be collected at the under-construction substation in Bahrabise Municipality-4 Bete.

The under-construction Liping Khola hydropower project is considered to be the fastest-completed project in Sindhupalchowk. According to the project, the total investment of the project is more than Rs. 3.4 billion.

The project is preparing to issue shares for general people in May. The project plans to issue 20 per cent of the investment (Rs. 266 million) shares to the public. Chaudhary said that they were preparing to issue 10 per cent of the IPO to the project-affected residents of Bhotekoshi and 10 per cent to the general public.

TOYOTA AUTOMAKER RESHUFFLES LEADERSHIP

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 16

Japanese automaker Daihatsu on Tuesday named a veteran at its parent company Toyota to replace its president as it tries to repair the damage from a scandal over cheating on vehicle safety tests.

The troubles at Daihatsu Motor Co. surfaced after a whistleblower reported the cheating. A third-party review found violations, such as carrying out tests on just one side of a car when both sides had to be tested, that had persisted for decades.

The appointments of a new president, executive vice president and director highlight Toyota's determination to play a leading role in the reforms at its 100% owned subsidiary.

Japan slips into a recession and loses its spot as the world's third-largest economy

AP
Tokyo, Feb. 16

Japan's economy is now the world's fourth-largest after it contracted in the last quarter of 2023 and fell behind Germany. The government reported the economy shrank at an annual rate of 0.4% in October to December, according to Cabinet Office data on real GDP released Thursday, though it grew 1.9% for all of 2023. It contracted 2.9% in July-September. Two straight quarters of contraction are considered an indicator an economy is in a technical recession.

Japan's economy was the second largest until 2010, when it was overtaken by China's. Japan's nominal GDP totaled $4.2 trillion last year, while Germany's was $4.4 trillion, or $4.5 trillion, depending on the currency conversion.

A weaker Japanese yen was a key factor in the drop to fourth place, since comparisons of nominal GDP are in dollar terms. But Japan's relative weakness also reflects a decline in its population and lagging productivity and competitiveness, economists say.

Real gross domestic product is a measure of the value of a nation's products and services. The annual rate measures what would have happened if the quarterly rate lasted a year.

Japan was historically touted as "an economic miracle," rising from the ashes of World War II to become the second largest economy after the U.S.. It kept that going through the 1970s and 1980s. But for most of the past 30 years the economy has grown only moderately at times, mainly remaining in the doldrums after the collapse of its financial bubble began in 1990.

Both the Japanese and German economies are powered by strong small and medium-size businesses with solid productivity.

Like Japan in the 1960s-1980s, for most of this century, Germany roared ahead, dominating global markets for high-end products like luxury cars and industrial machinery, selling so much to the rest of the world that half its economy ran on exports.

But its economy, one of the world's worst performing last year, also contracted in the last quarter, by 0.3%.

Britain's likewise contracted late last year. Britain reported Thursday that its economy entered a technical recession in October-December, shrinking 0.3% from the previous quarter.

CM Chaudhary emphasises women's entrepreneurship



PHOTO: TRN
Participants of 'National Women Entrepreneurs Conference-2080.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

The first 'National Women Entrepreneurs Conference-2080' involving women entrepreneurs from across the country kicked off in Bhairahawa on Friday.

The two-day conference is organised by the Women Entrepreneurs Development Committee of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FNCCI) in coordination with the FNCCI's Lumbini Provincial chapter and Siddhartha Chamber of Commerce and Industry (SCCI).

Speaking at the conference, women entrepreneurs drew the attention of the government and concerned agencies to the existing challenges of procedural requirements, training, capital, technology, skilled manpower and marketing.

According to them, there is a possibility of great economic progress from women entrepreneurs especially the micro, cottage and small enterprises, as these businesses can be operated by mobilising locally available resources with a little capital investment.

Speaking at the conference, Chief Minister of Lumbini Province, Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary, said that the village enterprises should be connected with the city. He informed that Lumbini Province had prepared an entrepreneurship programme to assure that the women could earn at least Rs. 30,000 or above per month.

CM Chaudhary said that Lumbini was ready to raise the necessary financial resources for the promotion of women entrepreneurship.

Home Minister of Lumbini, Santosh Pandey, said that the provincial government was ready to take up the responsibility of supporting women entrepreneurs. He said that the Lumbini government has taken initiatives to connect women entrepreneurship to the economy in addition to assisting in market promotion, branding and marketing of local products.

Likewise, Senior Vice-president of the FNCCI, Anjan Shrestha, stated that the government should create an environment for sustainable business along with the promotion of small entrepreneurs, the empowerment of women entrepreneurs and the promotion of economic prosperity.

Shrestha said that the FNCCI has repeatedly drawn the attention of the stakeholders regarding the need for providing financial access to women entrepreneurs and for that, facilities such as project mortgage loans, subsidised loans and refinancing should be made easy and effective.

President of FNCCI Lumbini, Krishna Prasad Sharma said that the conference was organised to listen to the problems of women entrepreneurs from across the country and get support for entrepreneurship development. He said that the conference would help in the development of entrepreneurship even outside the federal capital.

Similarly, Kamala Shrestha, Chairperson of the Women Entrepreneurs Development Committee, informed that the conference was organised with the aim of bringing the three levels of government and financial sector together to discuss the situation of women entrepreneurs, existing policy arrangements, practical challenges and solutions.

According to her, the recent increase in the activity of women in entrepreneurship and the increase in the participation of women in the labour force was a matter of happiness. "From 1971 to 2021, the percentage of economically active women over the age of 10 has increased from 29.2 per cent to 60.4 per cent," Shrestha said.

Nepalgunj-Janakpur flights from today

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Nepalgunj, Feb. 16

Preparations have reached the final stage to conduct inter-city flight services between Nepalgunj of Lumbini Province and Janakpur of Madhes Province.

In a new step towards materialising the service, Yeti Airlines is conducting two direct promotional flights from Nepalgunj to Janakpur on Saturday, February 17, and Monday, February 19.

This service is being implemented for the convenience of travellers and pilgrims who come to visit the Bageshwari Temple in Nepalgunj and the Janaki Temple in Janakpur, along with the pilgrims who want to visit the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, India. The distance between Nepalgunj and Ayodhya is 178 km. Tourism entrepreneurs are elated by the news.

Krishna Prasad Shrestha, Coordinator of Tourism Promotion Forum, Banke, said that he was very happy that the efforts made for a long have now started to bear fruit. He said that the direct air flight would connect the two religious cities of the Tarai and support tourism development. Keshav Neupane, a hotelier of Nepalgunj, stated that earlier efforts to establish air connectivity between Nepalgunj and Pokhara have resulted in an increased number of tourists.

He said that by connecting Janaki Temple and Bageshwari Temple with Ram Temple in Ayodhya and adding Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage to the package, the possibility of religious tourism could be promoted in the region.

Shriram Sigdel, President of Nepal Association of Tour and Travel Agents (NATA) Banke Chapter, said that the Association was working with plans to move forward by making Nepalgunj, the center of western Nepal a major transit for all types of tourism.

He said that there was no problem in making this city a major transit for tourism as it is easy to go to Kailash Mansarovar, Rara Lake, Swargadwari Ashram and Ayodhya from Nepalgunj. Sigdel also said that Nepalgunj-Janakpur direct air flight which will start from Saturday will add another dimension to it.

Prashant Bista, Mayor of Nepalgunj Sub-metropolitan City, expressed his gratitude to Yeti Airlines for starting the flight service as per the demand of tourism professionals in the region.

Chief of Yeti Airlines' Nepalgunj Office, Dilip Karki, said that two charter flights will be made from Nepalgunj to Janakpur on Saturday and Monday at the request of NATTA Banke to develop religious tourism.

He said that now two flights are being conducted to gauge the situation of the market and passengers and if the demand and number of passengers are good, the service would be provided regularly.



PHOTO: SIRAJ KHAN/TRN
Officials submitting a proposal seeking flight from Nepalgunj to Janakpur.

Mexico Senate endorses budget bill

AP
Santa Fe, N.M. Feb. 16

New Mexico would set aside well over $1 billion to guarantee tuition-free college and sustain government spending in case its oil production bonanza fades in the transition to cleaner energy sources under an annual spending plan endorsed by the state Senate on Monday.

The 31-10 Senate vote sends the bill back to the House for concurrence on amendments. The Democratic-led Legislature has until noon Thursday to send a budget bill to Democratic Gov. Michelle Lujan Grisham, who can approve or veto any provisions.

The bill as amended would increase annual general fund spending by $653 million, or 6.8%, to $10.2 billion for the fiscal year running from July 2024 through June 2025.

The boost in state spending is dwarfed by more than $1.3 billion in general fund transfers to new endowments and trusts designed to bolster scholarships for college and professional training, housing construction, outdoor conservation programs and autonomous Native American education programs.

Legislators anticipate a $3.5 billion budget surplus for the coming fiscal year, driven largely by oil and natural gas production in the Permian Basin that overlaps southwestern New Mexico and western Texas. Republican state Sen.

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STOCK

NEPSE	:	2,062.03
Total Amount	:	3,869,118,741.98
No. of Share	:	11,407,264

Writ filed against Karnali CM Office and ex-CM Shahi

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Surkhet, Feb. 16

A writ petition has been filed in Surkhet High Court against the Office of the Chief Minister of Karnali Province. Former Chief Minister Jeevan Bahadur Shahi has been made a defendant in the writ petition.

The writ was filed after a question was raised in a decision taken by the Council of Ministers of the Province on January 10, 2024.

The meeting of the Council of Ministers held on January 10 had decided to provide a transportation facility to former CM Jeevan Bahadur Shahi.

It was mentioned in the decision that Shahi, who is also a parliamentary leader of the Nepali Congress of Provincial Assembly, will be provided transportation facilities for 'the entire term of the current Karnali Provincial Assembly until he remains a member of the Provincial Assembly'.

In this regard, it was written in the decision that he would be provided a vehicle, a driver, a maximum vehicle maintenance cost of Rs. 150,000 per year from the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Law, and 200 liters of fuel per month from the office of the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers.

> The writ was filed after a question was raised in a decision taken by the Council of Ministers of the Province on January 10, 2024.

The decision was taken on the proposal of the current Office of the Chief Minister. The current CM of the province is Raj Kumar Sharma.

In Article 171 of the Constitution of Nepal, there is a provision regarding the remuneration and other facilities of the Chief Minister and Ministers.

Nidhi Raj Neupane, Spokesperson and Under-Secretary of the Ministry of Internal Affairs and Law said that it was decided that former Chief Minister Shahi would get a transport facility, but it has not been implemented.

He said that since the matter has entered the court, now the action will be taken as per the court's order.

Panel discussions begin in World Social Forum

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

Under the five-day World Social Forum (WSF) 2024 that started in Bhrikutimandap, Kathmandu, on Thursday, panel discussions on various social topics like health, education, gender and climate change began on Friday.

The panel discussions were held at Nepal Law Campus, RR Campus, City Hall and Bhrikutimandap Hall. Dramas and musical events on relevant topics were also presented.

Participants from diverse cultures and countries participated in the opening programme, each carrying distinct placards, collectively conveying the message of a hopeful vision for a better world.

The forum being held under the banner Another World is Possible, is believed to serve as a vital platform for open and horizontal exchanges among civil society organisations, social movements, trade unions and individuals opposing neoliberal globalisation.

The 16th edition of the WSF is focusing a myriad of pressing issues including economic inequality, climate justice, labour, migration, caste discrimination, gender equality, peace, sustainable development and many others.

The WSF has its roots in organising efforts from the Global South such as the 1992 Earth Summit in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. The first meeting of the WSF was held in Porto Alegre, Brazil, in January 2001 as an alternative to the World Economic Forum held annually in Davos, Switzerland.



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA\ TRN
Participants from Nepal and others countries attending good will rally organised by World Social Forum 2020, Nepal on Thursday.

By organising the event in Kathmandu, the WSF is regaining its strength and showing its relevance in today's world. Since its inception in 2001, the WSF has been a beacon for social movements, unions and activists to come together, share experiences and build strategies for change.

The forum featuring thematic panels, self-organised activities, and cultural programmes, the WSF 2024 aims to foster discussions, share experiences, and formulate strategies for a more equitable and sustainable future.

As of 10 February 2024, there are 1,252 organisations registered from 92 countries with 402 activities, ranging from trade unions, peasant organisations, women's organisations, Dalit organisations, youth organisations, minority groups, peace and justice movements, and environmental movements to several international organisations and academic institutions.

A series of thematic panels, assemblies and activities have been proposed by participating organisations under 13 different themes including climate justice and environmental sustainability, economic inequality and the global financial system, gender equality and women's rights, labour rights and migration, peace, justice, and human rights and indigenous peoples' rights and cultural preservation will be discussed.

Ex-Army Conference-2080 launched from Itahari

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

'Ex-Army Conference-2080' of the Nepali Army has formally begun from Itahari in Sunsari district of Koshi Province.

Chief of the Army Staff (CoAS) General Prabhu Ram Sharma formally inaugurated the conference in the Itahari-based Eastern Division Headquarters on Thursday. The conference will be held in a three-phase.

Addressing the ceremony, General Sharma said that ex-soldiers are leading a disciplined life as representative characters of the Nepali Army and are playing an important role as a bridge between the local people and the army, and informing the society about the remarkable works done by the army.

CoAS Sharma suggested that by following the institutional values and beliefs of the organisation, the knowledge, skills and experience gained during military service should be applied for the development and upliftment of the community and society and play a leadership role in the society in times of need, including disasters.

The General said that in accordance with the policy of expansion and effective management of welfare services for the benefit of the serving and retired soldiers from the NA Welfare Fund collected from the blood and sweat of the entire ranks of the Nepali Army.



Gaurav Tandul, Chief Executive Officer of the NA Welfare Board and retired Lieutenant General, informed about various services and facilities being conducted for ex-soldiers by the conference and the NA Welfare Fund.

According to Directorate of Public Relations and Information of the Army Headquarters, 87,200 ex-armies are enjoying pensions after resigning/retiring from the service while 16,211 families are receiving the pensions.

The army has been conducting various programmes of education, health, skills and self-employment and services and concessions to improve the living standards of the beneficiaries. The number of beneficiaries receiving services including health and education from the NA Fund is more than 1 million.

It was informed on the occasion that the NA Welfare Fund has a fund of Rs. 82.66 billion.

At the ceremony held in Itahari, 93-year-old corporal Ganga Bahadur Katwal of Sunsari and late corporal Dilli Bahadur Khatri's wife Bhim Kumari Luintel Khatri were honoured.

Apart from Itahari, Ex-army Conferences were also held in Dhankuta, Gaighat of Udayapur, Charaali (Jhapa), Panchthar and Okhaldhunga. In Charali, Jhapa, a two-day health camp was also organmised.

According to the Directorate of Public Relations and Information of the Army Headquarters, in the second phase, the conference will be held in Bharatpur (Chitwan) and Trishuli (Nuwakot) under Central Division Headquarters on February 23.

Similarly, the third and last session of the Conference will be held on March 17, 2024, at the Valley Division Headquarters in the participation of Kathmandu, Lalitpur, Bhaktapur, Kavrepalanchok and Sindhupalchok districts' ex-soldiers.

Meanwhile, our district correspondent from Hile, Dhankuta stated that the Ex-Army Conference-2080 orgainsed at Shree No. 3 Brigade Headquarters, Hile, Dhankuta, concluded on Thursday.

The conference for the ex-army men was held on the premises of the Brigade Headquarters in Dhankuta targeting four districts of Tehrathum, Bhojpur, Sankhuwasabha and Dhankuta itself.

The conference was held and concluded in the presence of the Chief of the Brigade and Brigadier General Ramkaji Rapa on Wednesday.

According to the Nepali Army, the conference was attended by 615 ex-army personnel from the four districts. On the occasion, different cultural dances and parades were performed.

MALE TIGER FOUND DEAD IN NAWALPUR



PHOTO: BOM LAL GIRI
The dead male tiger found in a forest of Arunkhola, in Madhyabindu Municipality-10, Nawalpur.

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Feb. 16

A male tiger was found dead in a forest of Arunkhola, in Madhyabindu Municipality-10, Nawalpur.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Nawalpur Bed Bahadur Paudel said that it was unclear whether the tiger died naturally or was killed. However, Division Forest Officer Arjun Sapkota said that the tiger might have died of natural causes.

Paudel added that a team comprising police and officials from the Division Forest Office in Kawasoti reached the incident site to investigate the circumstances surrounding the tiger's demise.

Based on the tiger's condition, it is presumed to have passed away several days ago, the Division Forest Office said.

Embankment built to save river bank Ram Temple

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Myagdi (Beni): Feb. 16

A concrete embankment has been constructed to protect the Ram Mandir, a religious place which was at high risk of being eroded by the Kaligandaki and Raghuganga Rivers.

A composite wall of 138 meters long has been constructed on the bank of Kaligandaki River under the Ram Temple Conservation Plan at Jaljala Rural Municipliayt-2 of Parbat in the Galeshwor area.

The Rupatal Conservation Integrated Development Project of Pokhara under the Department of Water Resources and Irrigation had signed a contract with Machhapuchchhre Construction Service on January 23, 2023, for Rs. 43.2 million to complete the embankment within two years.

The contractor started the construction works by mobilising sufficient workers and equipment. Although the contract was signed to complete the project by December 22, 2024, it is going to be completed 10 months before the deadline. Now, the construction work has reached the final stage.

Bal Bahadur Sunuwar, an assistant contractor of Machhapuchhre Construction Service, said, "We commenced construction works in February/March last year.

The work was stopped for a few months in the rainy season. We have accelerated the construction by mobilising 30 to 40 workers daily, and we are preparing to complete all the work within this month."

Ashok Timilsina, sub-engineer of the Rupatal Conservation Integrated Development Project, said that a two-and-a-half-metre cut-off with a width of 50 centimeters has been constructed under the ground and a four-metre wide composite wall with a height of three meters has been erected above the ground.

Three years ago, a massive flood in the Kaligandaki River damaged the famous Ram Mandir, located at the confluence of the Kaligandaki and Raghuganga Rivers.

The structures including the Dharamshala of the temple were washed away by the flood. The temple, the priest's residence and the suspension bridge connecting Galeshwor to Ram Temple were also damaged.

Eight major projects are currently under construction to protect Beni Bazaar and surrounding settlements, which are at high risk of erosion by the Kaligandaki and Myagdi Rivers.

The Rupatal Conservation Integrated Development Project, Pokhara, has been implementing projects worth Rs. 480 million since last year to protect the settlements around Beni Bazaar, Galeshwor area and Parbat Beni area.

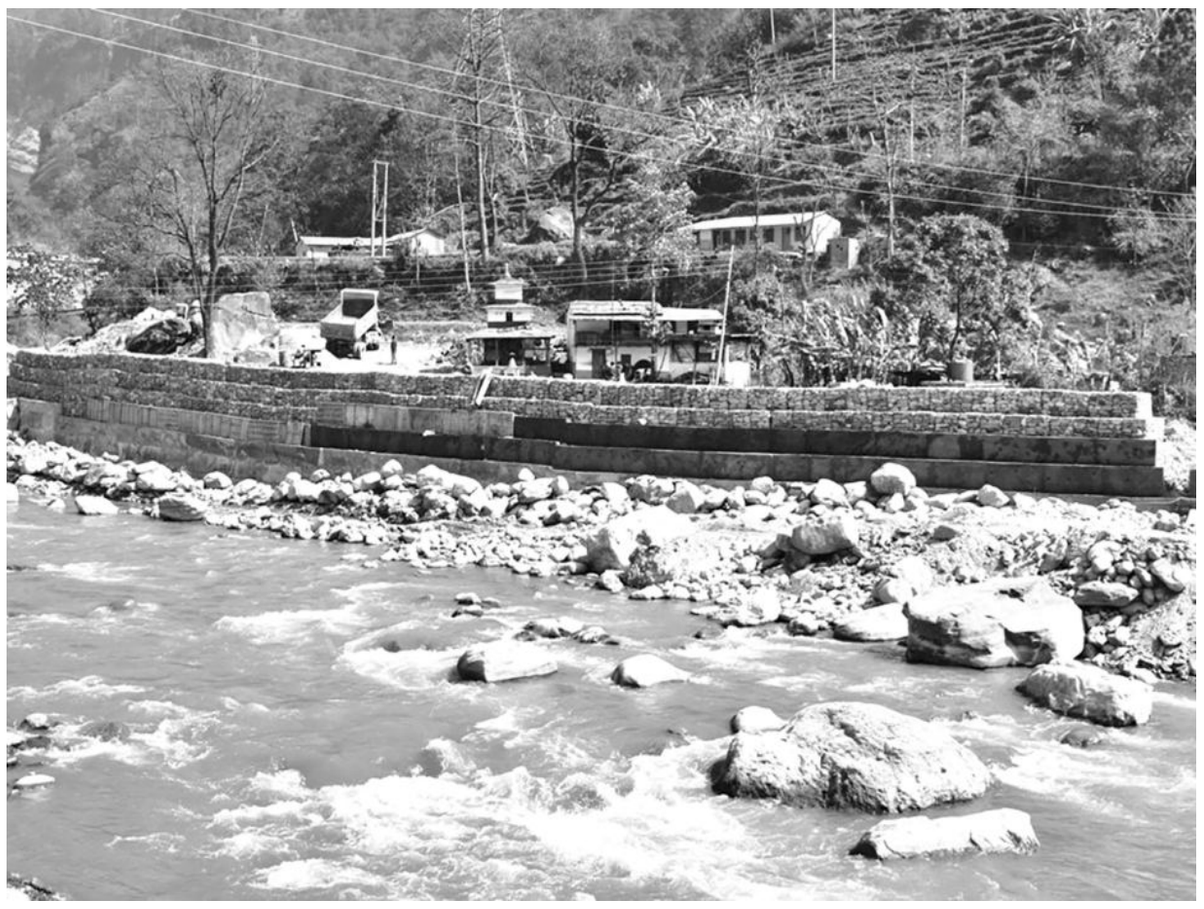


PHOTO: TRN
The concrete embankment constructed to protect the Ram Mandir, a religious place that was at high risk of erode by the Kaligandaki and Raghuganga Rivers.

WOMAN DIES OF SNAKE BITE IN JHAPA

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Birtamod, Feb. 16

A woman died after being bitten by a snake in Kachankawal, Jhapa, at 11:30 am on Thursday.

Tikamaya Dahal, a 65-year-old resident of Kachankawal-1, was bitten by a snake while working in the field.

Dahal, who sustained injuries from the snake bite, was brought to Birtamod's B&C Hospital for treatment. Police confirmed that she died during the course of treatment.

Snake bite incidents are rare in winter. This is the first reported case of snakebite death this winter.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Life is really simple, but we insist on making it complicated.

-- Confucius

Rediscovering Balanced Foreign Policy

Dev Raj Dahal



Nepal's foreign policy goals are well articulated in its constitution. They offer a frame and choices for leadership to define the values, institutions, processes and strategies in attaining them. Owing to a lack of full grasp of constitutional duty and conduct, courage and imagination about them, Nepali foreign policy is, however, less tuned to coherence, balance and effectiveness. As a result, it is self-limiting the nation's credibility, capacity and diplomacy. The world is now more divided than the past with the surge of several poles of power where each has its own purpose. They are engaged in various scales of relationship with each other, sometimes overstretching influence and even overstepping in the internal affairs of other states. National interests, defined as an ultimate priority to self, are a vital force before the fleeting ideologies and regime compatibility with the external world.

Considering this fact, Nepali leadership has to build a frame beyond leadership perception of regime survival, change or partisan manoeuvring. It should be governed by the national, constitutional, intergenerational and enlightened interests. But when it is tied with leaders' self-interests in position and wealth pump it misses the spell of gearing, a careful balancing act required by the nation's strategic pivot between two great powers of Asia - Bharat and China - to have evocative engagements. It is vital for the diversification of the nation's security, political and economic ties, ensure its sovereignty and ease an escape from the corrosive spillover of the upending world order. Without being trapped in a security dilemma, Nepali leadership needs to engage with multiple poles of power for its independent manoeuvre, diversify ties affirming the policy of non-alignment and chart multitask strategies for peoples' wellbeing.

The implicit fear of secular Nepali leadership to remain paranoid over Bharat's cultural reconstruction and decolonisation and the Chinese moral support to it may compel it to rethink about its smug attitude and amnesia of the nation's cultural powerhouse of soft power, the source of its intellectual heritage and identity. Powerful societal actors, especially business, civil society, functional groups and civilisational forces influence foreign policies yet do not assume mutual accountability in shaping the conduct. Nepali constitution's vision of the right to work marks a divorce with its economic diplomacy of exporting capital, labour, students and entrepreneurs while they are needed the most in the nation's progress.

One-sided dependence

The establishment of Nepal has converging foreign policy interests glued by neo-liberal economy, democratic fraternity, communication, educational and legal policies and shared worldview with the Anglosphere which propelled it to illicitly privatise all Chinese- and Russian-made import-substituting industries and broke the backward and forward linkages of the nation's agriculture and industry to trade and commerce. The neo-liberal ideological consensus among the elites of various political spectrums has entirely shifted the country's geo-economy of mercantilism pursued by Prithvi Narayan Shah to excessive import, remittance, aid and debt-dependent landscape thus plunging the economy to downhill, laying poverty trap and propelling youths' emigration abroad en masse. The consequence of one-sided dependence on elite preference has consumed the nation's balance and dynamics. The increasing Asianisation of world politics especially with the pivoting of the US, European, Arabic, African and Latin American nations, including Russia entails Nepal to rethink balancing its policies beyond the Anglosphere.

Ironically, its ties with Russia are getting frosty while with China cooperation is confined with verbal pedantry, delaying the execution of commitments and agreements signed on mutually beneficial cooperation. The Chinese Vice-Minister Sun Haiyan, representing the International Department of the Communist Party of China while holding debate with Nepali political leaders of various hues, revealed that the political relations between Nepal and China are good but "some countries do not want to see this" and, therefore, it is working hard to boost ties with Nepal by implementing the bilaterally agreed areas of cooperation. Chinese President Xi Xinping, in his speech to the Communist Party Congress, stated that China's foreign policy "offers a new option for other nations who want to speed up their development while preserving their independence."

China's moral and emotional support to Bharat's indigenisation is premised on the fact of its growing self-confidence in its own version of democracy and foreign policy, not succumbing to the Western nations' animus to China and Russia. Bharat's increasing self-defining moment is also inspiring many Asian, African and Latin American nations to follow suit, considering it an independent power with its own global aspirations. China has offered Bharat to cooperate in the development of Nepal as both have great stake in its stability and progress. The West's pivoting to Asia and turning Nepal one of the conduits of this strategy has increased the Chinese stake in Nepal for reasons of security of Tibet, protection of its growing investment, future of its pro-active diplomacy on global security, development and civilisation and transforming it from "landlocked to land-linked nation."

The Chinese ideological preference in Nepal is now shifted to realpolitik of engaging with all sides so that it does not entangle with anti-Chinese forces. Nepali regime has also set aside EPG report, review of peace and friendship treaty, trade deficits, Kalapani imbroglios, etc. and entered into cooperation with Bharat allowing it to invest

> Multi-civilisation world order offers small states like Nepal better freedom of action for security, survival, progress and identity provided the establishment does not confiscate state power and its ability of national self-determination.

in hydropower, scale up money for the high impact community development and stated to become "comfortable with India." It has, however, provoked the utterance of counter-elites. Nepal's statecraft entails realpolitik placing the purpose of balancing the interests of great powers above the neo-liberal affinity defined by ideological worldview without glossing over the concerns of Sino-Russian power charging ahead.

It is rash to ditch Russia which has asked for detailed proposals from Nepal for 13 projects on May 4, 2023. If animated, it would have transformative potential. The projects include the construction of electric railways, highways and cancer hospitals for children, increase of the scholarship quota for Nepali students to study in Russia with its own investment and resume direct flight between two nations interrupted since 2002. The Chinese and Russian proposals seem to have been sloughed off while the American MCC and Bharat's high impact community development are in full swing while the State Partnership Programme is in partial execution. Nepal still needs Russia's partnership like the former Soviet Union which along with China contributed to its industrial set up and human and infrastructural development.

Russia keeps a strategic leverage with Bharat, China, Africa and the Gulf region on which Nepal's non-aligned policy flourishes; the latter is the source of its remittance flow, the lifeblood of the national economy. Improving relations with Russia and the nation's reindustrialisation can cut linear dependence, capacitate its diplomatic muscle and ease a constructive talk for Nepalis' return from the Russian army fighting against Ukraine. But it also requires Nepal not to remain reticent but to persuade Ukraine not to employ Nepalis in its army to fight against Russia. Nepal's independent foreign policy now finds itself on the cusp of many impediments. First, its personalisation by top leadership lacking the anchor of institutional memory and inputs from the epistemic community. It is an epistemic community which can bring updated and specialised knowledge to foreign policy decisions in dealing with the correlation of various levels of power and avert the risk of resistance that opposes Nepal's unity, progress and peace.

Second, its leaders' deliberate refusal to follow diplomatic code and Foreign Ministry's guidelines while meeting foreign diplomats and dignitaries in the nation and abroad has compressed international and national laws and diplomatic codes, thus reducing Foreign Ministry, the central institution of foreign policy articulation, to triviality. Ambassadors of certain powerful nations meet high officials without presenting their credentials. Third, personalised and partisan style of appointing ambassadors without any consideration for their edifying account of history, institutional memory, intellectual heft, dexterity and language proficiency but slouching towards the antiquated boudoir diplomacy makes them loyal to leaders, not to the Nepali nation thus sullying national image and acceptability. Similarly, the secret diplomacy associated with it has become passé in the modern times with the proliferation of communication, social media, mobile phones, digital cameras and the invention of multi-track diplomacy where the support of the public is required to it to become legitimate, credible and successful.

Societal actors

Refusal to comply with the protocol has flagged the integrity of polity in global politics. Fourth, lacking conformity between old style international relations that support official interaction to a shift to global relations where not only the state actors are the keys of interactions abroad but also the societal actors are engaged in cross-border transactions, posturing and rallying, some even anti-state, thus turning the context of foreign policy more interdependent. Multi-civilisation world order offers small states like Nepal better freedom of action for security, survival, progress and identity provided the establishment does not confiscate state power and its ability of national self-determination, subdue internal foes tied to various geopolitical poles and set the convergence of the state, economy and people in national space to tune with Asianisation of world politics and overcome its impediments.

At a time of waning of multilateralism and institutions of global governance by the effects of direct or proxy wars of great powers and the growth of parallel rival initiatives and institutions of security, economy and geopolitical flirtation, Nepal too needs careful reframing of balancing of their interests, not retreating to imbalance and disengagement from the Eurasian pole and concentrate only on its rival for reason of elites' Westernizing ambition. The nation has emerged as a biggest contributor of peace troops in the UN but vulnerable to internal insecurity including that of geopolitical penetration, dependency, poverty, depopulation of the nation and climate change. It is high time to unwind ideological barriers or rationalisations only and prevent domestic flaws swelling outward so as not to tear the frame of its historically evolved security and foreign policy of balance, credibility and effectiveness.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

China's Coffee Market

MITCHELL BLATT

When I last lived in China, it was easy to find an intersection in Shanghai with a Starbucks shop on every street corner. Now, four years later, China has even more coffee shops – and it's not just foreign brands like Starbucks.

Driven largely by the growth of domestic brands like Luckin Coffee, China has surpassed South Korea as the country with the most branded coffee shops in the world. Shanghai was already the city with the most coffee shops in the world in 2021. However, China still does not have the most coffee shops per capita when compared to its large population – South Korea and Japan rank first and second in that regard.

What might be surprising to some is that China already surpassed the United States in terms of coffee shops years ago. With 49,691 cafes, China has over 10,000 more cafes than the United States, according to Project Café 2023.

Americans do drink a lot of coffee – 3.1 kilograms worth of beans per capita, according to Euromonitor – compared to 2.6 kilograms per capita for South Koreans and less for Chinese.

But Americans typically enjoy their morning coffee at home, and we don't have the same social coffee culture as Asians or Europeans living in densely-populated cities.

Luckin Coffee, China's leading branded coffee shop with 13,000 outlets, has grown by focusing on creative coffee-based drinks. Their online menu lists their top three sellers: the coconut latte, a latte enriched with coconut milk that is subtly sweet and smooth; the velvet latte, which is made creamy and silky with Hokkaido milk; and the creamy dreamy latte. An iced minty coconut latte is one of Luckin's newest additions.

What is immediately clear is the importance of a smooth textured drinking experience for many of Luckin's drinks. China does not have a long history of coffee consumption as many European countries do. Coffee often tastes bitter to infrequent drinkers of the stuff. Tea is China's drink of choice, so Luckin has many drinks that mix coffee and tea.

They also have a lot of drinks that blend coffee and juice. Their Exfreezo blended coffee drink, for example, comes in flavors such as matcha, peach jasmine, and mango jasmine.

Luckin's comeback focused on attracting customers through quality and taste rather than racing to the bottom on price. When it first started, Luckin mostly only sold ordinary coffee drinks at extremely low prices. The prices were so low that the company couldn't make a profit. Students and workers just drank it for its affordability and convenience, but it didn't build lasting customers with brand loyalty, leading to an accounting scandal. Now, by focusing on producing unique and tasty products, it can increase prices and attract customers who like its specialty creations.

The profitable coffee industry in China has also attracted interest from other existing players and new entrants. Starbucks, which has over 6,800 locations in China, opened over 850 new stores this year and has plans to reach 9,000 by 2025. That would require even faster growth of 13% per year, above the company's current annual growth rate of 10%.

In addition, another local startup, Cotti Coffee, is expanding aggressively. Cotti Coffee already has 6,061 locations in 28 countries after just having been launched by a couple of former Luckin executives in August 2022. Cotti seems to be focusing on the low-price strategy that Luckin pursued early on. Their Americano cost half the price of a leading competitor's Americano when they opened their first shop in Thailand this month. Cotti already has shops open in South Korea, Indonesia, and Japan, among other countries.

Luckin opened its first foreign location in Singapore in early 2023, and now has 24 stores there. One of its most innovative drinks is the Big Cheese Latte, which uses New Zealand cream cheese and aromatic blends of coffee.

Manner Coffee has had a different growth trajectory. It grew slowly from just one stall on the street of Shanghai to over 300 stores as of 2021. Other smaller local cafe brands include M Stand and Seesaw Coffee. Canadian coffee leader Tim Hortons is also aggressively expanding in China with over 700 stores targeted at "underpenetrated cities," especially those in the northeast.

The different strategies of different companies show the many possibilities for growth in the Chinese coffee market.

-- China.org.cn

Bulls In Nepal: Triggering Aspects

Dwaipayan Regmi



NEPSE, whose history is not long, had to move around the index of starting point 100 since its establishment and operation in the year 1994. It was finally after 1999, the market started its bullish trend till it reached the peak of the index, making it 545.82 on November 23, 2000 - the 'First Bull Record' in Nepal's market. With 445.82 per cent of absolute return, NEPSE gained popularity in limited regions, basically within the capital. With positive hopes in the economy, investors looked for places to invest, leading to this first bull - where every ray of hope was positive. Despite ongoing civil war, there were positive hopes and it was believed that industries and manufacturing would shape the market sooner or later, taking the entire market to a new height.

But, the irony part is - after every bull, there is a bear that comes around. Hence, the market had to drop down gradually due to the influences of civil war and diminishing interest in its production. Increased migration level then equally contributed. The market started gaining height in 2006 and then reached the highest point in August 2008 with an index of 1175.38. Nepal was going through historical political change during this time. There was the end of 10-year-long civil war and the monarchy was removed, which created positive hopes in the political arena. It also brought out massive expectations of political stability, which was highly pessimistic earlier - raising the confidence level of investors.

Confidence level

The reason for this bull was all about the hope that political dimensions would hold because of which migration was also seen. As people started moving towards capital and urban cities, there was an increased demand for loans during this time, so market obtained 531.18 per cent of absolute return.

Thereafter it was in 2016, eight years later, NEPSE got to sense the next big bull where the index was as high as 1881.45 when the market gained 543.63 per cent of the total gain. The reason for this bull was confidence level raised: Nepal did overcome earthquake impact amid economic blockade imposed by India. There had been massive charm in real estate during this era, because of which the proportion of loans disbursed by banks also raised, leading to the downfall of interest rates which ultimately affected diminishing charm in fixed deposits. There were new investors during this bull which equally boosted the index level.

Finally, the fourth bull that Nepal got to see was in the year 2021. With global optimistic views regarding COVID-19 vaccines, and the lockdown being wrapped up, the investors got to realise that the share market is that space that would exist even during massive emergencies. Besides, Nepal's share market was gaining technological advantages during this era when the online access was on the rise. Be it online DEMAT account access, online IPO application practices, or easy TMS account opening - there was

> Whether it's the desire of the mass population who would rather want to invest in safer bet like gold, or political factors like government intervention, budget, or election, they equally contribute to providing shape to the market.

a large number of active participants. As a result, the share market was no longer limited to big cities but went into access of every individual from Hangpang of Taplejung to Khalanga of Darchula.

Additionally, there were favourable monetary and fiscal policies launched, promoting a decrease of interest rates and increment of the money supply. What's more, those who were doing normal businesses had nowhere to invest because of the pandemic, and the youths who returned to Nepal had nowhere to invest - they found a big arena - taking the market to the next height with an index of 3198.38 with a return of 190.63 per cent. It was not just an index this time, but the volume of turnover also saw a massive improvement.

Seeing the case of the Indian stock market index, basically SENSEX, factors - such as government policies, RBI policies, SEBI policies, exchange rates, interest rates of banks, and inflation rates - all sum up to push the market upward and catch a new record. Whether it's the desire of the mass population who would rather want to invest in safer bet like gold, or political factors like government intervention, budget, or election, they equally contribute to providing shape to the market. The bull of 2001 was mainly backed up by economic factors, where several BFIs were progressing with optimistic hopes and legal factors with improvised regulatory practices.

Similarly, the bull of 2008, was led by political force (end of civil war) and socio-cultural factors (increased migration); that of 2016 was because of environmental reasons (earthquake impact) the case of the fourth bull of 2021 was a consequence of technological factor (increased TMS and online access).

PESTLE factors

Hence, there has to be a presence of any one reason or multiple reasons for a bull to hit the market. As of now, Nepal's PESTLE (Political, Economic, Sociological, Technological, Legal and Environment) has not been in any phase. Indeed, interest rates are in a lowering trend, but that does not provide concrete shape and reason for the bull to hit the high record of 3198.38. There have to be reasons. It is a pretty known fact that PESTLE factors are not within the hand of any individual, so the bull will come out naturally as the next gift of the external environment. Had this been predictable, someone who would predict would be at the top of the list, but bull and bear - they are part, and they will occur - there is no option besides being patient here.

(Regmi is deputy manager at Rastriya Banijya Bank Ltd.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 17, 1974

Measles Cases

Mahendranagar, Feb. 16: About 19 boys and girls of Pipalari village and the surrounding areas of Jhelari village panchayat are suffering from measles, it is learnt, reports RSS

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P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Facilitate Hydel Projects



This is in reference to the news headlined "*Supervision consultant selected for 1,063 MW Upper Arun*" published in this daily on Feb. 16. Since the hydel project is semi-reservoir project, it is more beneficial to Nepal compared to its run-of-the-river counterparts, which is why it is has been declared to be the game changer project in the country's hydropower sector.

And this comes at a time when electricity generation has been reaching newer highs breaking past records, enabling us to export it to neighbouring India during the rainy season. What's more, because the contract has been signed with two European companies with unmatched expertise on the sector, it can be hoped that the construction of the project will be of highest standard.

It goes without saying that the more electricity we generate, the more prosper we become. What matters now is its timely completion. The government should act as a facilitator that leaps into action whenever a project encounters a problem.

Kapil Basyal
Texas

TAILPIECE

I recently had a visitor from the state of Texas. For three days all I heard from him was "In Texas we have the best this, the largest that, the fastest that," etc. It eventually became very annoying.

Being from Niagra Falls, I thought I could outdo him by showing him the "Mighty Niagara", knowing there was nothing in Texas that could compare to this "Wonder of Water and Power".

While standing at the brink watching millions of gallons of water rushing over, I noticed the look of awe in his eyes. It was then I asked him: "Do you have anything like this in Texas?"

He waited a moment before he answered: "No, but we have a plumber that could fix it."

UK voters deliver double blow to PM Rishi Sunak

AP
London, Feb. 16



PHOTO: AP

Labour Party candidate Gen Kitchen celebrates with her family after being declared winner in the Wellingborough by-election at the Kettering Leisure Village, Northamptonshire, Friday Feb. 16, 2024.

Voters in two districts in England delivered new blows to beleaguered Prime Minister Rishi Sunak, electing opposition-party lawmakers in seats that Sunak's Conservatives had held for years. Labour Party candidate Damien Egan won the House of Commons seats of Kingswood in southwest England, and Labour's Gen Kitchen took Wellingborough in the country's centre, results announced Friday showed. The Conservatives won both by large margins at the last national election in 2019 but saw support collapse in Thursday's special elections.

The hard-right Reform U.K. — formerly known as the Brexit Party — came third, putting more pressure on the Conservatives.

Labour leader Keir Starmer said the results "show people want change."

The results will likely worsen fears among Conservatives that, after 14 years in power, the party is heading for defeat when a national election is held in less than a year. The Tories consistently lag between 10 and 20 points behind the left-of-centre Labour in opinion polls.

Thursday's elections replaced two lawmakers who left suddenly, one in protest, the other under a cloud.

Lawmaker Chris Skidmore quit the Kingswood seat last month to protest Sunak's lack of commitment to green energy. Long-serving Wellingborough legislator Peter Bone was ousted over allegations of bullying and sexual misconduct.

The Conservatives have now lost 10 by-elections since the last general election, more than any administration since the 1960s. That includes six defeats — and one win — since Sunak took office in October 2022. He replaced Liz Truss, who rocked the economy with a plan for unfunded tax cuts and lasted just seven weeks in office.

Sunak, the fifth Conservative leader since 2016, has restored a measure of stability, but failed to revive the governing party's popularity.

The Conservatives have been in power nationally since 2010, years that saw austerity following the world banking crisis, Britain's divisive decision to leave the European Union, a global pandemic and a European war that triggered the worst cost-of-living crisis in decades.

Polls show the Conservatives are losing support across the country, from affluent southern voters turned off by Brexit to working-class northern voters who switched from Labour for the 2019 election, when then-Prime Minister Boris Johnson promised to spread prosperity to long-neglected areas. Those promises remain largely unmet, and Britain's economic growth has come to a virtual standstill, with the country slipping into recession at the end of 2023 for the first time since the onset of the coronavirus pandemic.

"In Kingswood, as across the country, 14 years of Conservative government have sucked the hope out of our country with a feeling that no matter how hard you work, you just can't move forward," Egan said in his victory speech.

Verdict in Trump's civil fraud trial soon

AP
New York, Feb. 16



PHOTO: AP

Former President Donald Trump attends the closing arguments in the Trump Organization civil fraud trial at New York State Supreme Court in the Manhattan borough of New York, Jan. 11, 2024.

A verdict is expected Friday in Donald Trump's New York civil fraud trial, adding to a consequential week on the former president's legal calendar.

Trump could be hit with millions of dollars in penalties and other sanctions in the decision by Judge Arthur Engoron, who has already ruled that the former president inflated his wealth on financial statements that were given to banks, insurers and others to make deals and secure loans.

New York Attorney General Letitia James is seeking $370 million and a ban on Trump and other defendants from doing business in the state. A penalty like that could potentially wound the real estate empire that helped Trump craft his image as a savvy billionaire businessman and vaulted him to fame and the White House.

Engoron is set to rule after 2½ months of testimony from 40 witnesses, including Trump. Closing arguments were held Jan. 11. The judge is deciding the case because juries are not allowed in this type of lawsuit and neither James' office nor Trump's lawyers asked for one.

Engoron is expected to release his decision Friday, barring unforeseen circumstances that would necessitate a delay, court officials said.

It has already been a big week in court for Trump. On Thursday, a different New York judge ruled that Trump will stand trial March 25 on charges that he falsified his company's records as part of an effort to buy the silence of people with potentially embarrassing stories about alleged infidelity. Trump says he is innocent.

If the schedule holds, it will be the first of his four criminal cases to go to trial. Also Thursday, a judge in Atlanta heard arguments on whether to remove Fulton County District Attorney Fani Willis from Trump's Georgia election interference case because she had a personal relationship with a special prosecutor she hired.

James' office has estimated that Trump exaggerated his wealth by as much as $3.6 billion. State lawyers contend Trump used the inflated numbers to get lower insurance premiums and favorable loan terms, saving at least $168 million on interest alone.

Trump has denied wrongdoing and his lawyers have said they'll appeal if Engoron rules against him.

The Republican presidential front-runner testified Nov. 6 that his financial statements actually understated his net worth and that banks did their own research and were happy with his business. During closing arguments in January, he decried the case as a "fraud on me."

Mexico likely to elect woman as its next prez



PHOTO: AP

This combination of two file photos shows Xochitl Galvez, at left, arriving to register her name as a presidential candidate on July 4, 2023 in Mexico City.

AP
Mexico City, Feb. 16

Mexico is almost certain to elect its first female president in June — both leading candidates are women — but it's almost equally as certain that she won't have much room to act independently of outgoing President Andrés Manuel López Obrador.

The populist president has continued proposing new, expensive projects in the closing months of his administration, before he leaves office on Sept. 30. He will also leave a lot of big-ticket projects unfinished.

That will probably leave his successor with her hands tied for much of her six-year term. Even if opposition candidate Xóchitl Gálvez wins, a mountain of financial commitments will weigh on her. The candidate of López Obrador's party, former Mexico City mayor Claudia Sheinbaum, leads in polls. A third male candidate from a small party has almost no chance of winning.

López Obrador has said that before he steps down, he'll expropriate U.S.-owned Vulcan Materials, a move which could cost the Mexican government as much as $1.9 billion if the Alabama-based quarry company wins an ongoing international arbitration complaint against Mexico.

Then there is a yet-to-be-fleshed-out promise to bring passenger trains back to Mexico before he leaves office. On Nov. 20, López Obrador published a decree stating that if private freight operators refuse to run passenger service, the government would step in to do so.

Patients die as oxygen runs out in Gaza hospital

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Feb. 16



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians look at the destruction after an Israeli strike on a residential building in Rafah, Gaza Strip, Friday, Feb. 16, 2024.

The storming by Israeli troops of southern Gaza's main hospital brought chaos to hundreds of staff and patients inside, as health officials Friday said four people in intensive care died after their oxygen cut off. Troops were searching the facility, where the military said it believes the remains of hostages abducted by Hamas might be located.

The raid came after troops had besieged Nasser Hospital in the southern city of Khan Younis for nearly a week, with staff, patients and others inside struggling under heavy fire and dwindling supplies, including food and water. Hours before troops seized the hospital Thursday, Israeli fire killed a patient and wounded six others inside the complex, staff said.

Negotiations over a cease-fire in Gaza, meanwhile, appear to have stalled, and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Friday pushed back hard against the U.S. vision for after the war — particularly its calls for the creation of a Palestinian state. After speaking overnight with President Joe Biden, Netanyahu wrote on X that Israel will not accept "international dictates regarding a permanent settlement with the Palestinians."

He said that if other countries unilaterally recognize a Palestinian state, it would give a "reward to terrorism." Netanyahu has repeatedly rejected creation of a Palestinian state.

Netanyahu has vowed to continue the offensive and expand it to the Gaza city of Rafah, near Egypt, until Hamas is destroyed and scores of hostages taken during the militants' Oct. 7 attack are freed.

In their phone call, Biden again cautioned Netanyahu against moving forward with a military operation in Rafah before coming up with a "credible and executable plan" to ensure the safety of Palestinian civilians, the White House said.

With the war showing no sign of ending, the risk of a broader conflict grew as Israel and Lebanon's Hezbollah militant group had deadliest exchange of fire along the border since the start of the Israel-Hamas war.

PRISM

Raccoons steal DoorDash tacos

Florida: A Florida woman took out her phone and started recording when a trio of masked bandits stole her DoorDash taco order from in front of her door.

Caterina Sevares said she opened the front door of her West Palm Beach apartment to retrieve her DoorDash order from Talkin' Tacos, but she instead came face to face with three raccoons who were enjoying her late-night meal.

"My jaw dropped," Sevares told WOFL-TV. Sevardes took out her phone and recorded video of the scene, which she posted to TikTok.

"Once they started hissing, I shut the door so fast. I was like, 'They can have the carne asada, it's fine,'" Sevares said.

Escaped horse found wandering in N.C. road

North Carolina: Police in North Carolina came to the rescue of an escaped horse found wandering loose down the middle of a road.

The Greenville Police Department said in a Facebook post that members of its Animal Services Unit responded to a report of a horse walking down the middle of MacGregor Downs Road.

Officers discovered the horse, named Bobo, had fled home "after getting into a scuffle with the resident stallion."

The owner is recovering from a broken shoulder, so officers helped by leading the horse home while a patrol car followed with caution lights flashing.

(AP)

Greece legalises same-sex marriage

AP
Athens, Feb. 16



PHOTO: AP

Supporters of same-sex marriage bill take part in a rally, at central Syntagma Square, in Athens, Greece, Thursday, Feb. 15, 2024.

Greece has become the first majority-Orthodox Christian nation to legalize same-sex marriage under civil law. At least for the near future, it will almost certainly be the only one.

Eastern Orthodox leadership, despite lacking a single doctrinal authority like a pope, has been united in opposing recognition of same-sex relationships both within its own rites and in the civil realm. Public opinion in majority Orthodox countries has mostly been opposed, too.

But there are some signs of change. Two small majority-Orthodox countries, Montenegro and Cyprus, have authorized same-sex unions in recent years, as did Greece in 2015 before upgrading to this week's approval of full marital status.

Civil unions may become more common among Orthodox countries gravitating toward the European Union. They remain off the table in Russia, which has cracked down on LGBTQ+ expression, and countries in its orbit.

Following is a summary of church positions and public opinion in the Orthodox world, followed by the situation in individual majority-Orthodox lands.

Eastern Orthodoxy is a socially conservative, ancient church with elaborate rituals and a strict hierarchy. Churches are mostly organized along national lines, with multiple independent churches that share ancient doctrine and practices and that both cooperate and squabble.

Roughly 200 million Eastern Orthodox live primarily in Eastern Europe and neighbouring Asian lands, with about half that total in Russia, while smaller numbers live across the world. Like other international church bodies, Orthodoxy has confronted calls for LGBTQ+ inclusion.

A 2016 statement by a council of most Orthodox churches called marriage between a man and a woman "the oldest institution of divine law" and said members were forbidden from entering same-sex unions.

In countries where they are a majority, Orthodox believers overwhelmingly said society should not accept homosexuality or approve same-sex marriage, according to surveys conducted in 2015 and 2016 by the Pew Research Centre, a Washington-based think tank.

Greek Orthodox showed relative tolerance, with half of Orthodox saying homosexuality should be accepted and a quarter favouring same-sex marriage. In more recent polls, Greeks overall narrowly supported the marriage law.

The Greek law validates marriage in the civil realm but doesn't require any church to perform such rites.

Nevertheless, Greece's Orthodox leadership unanimously opposed the law in January, saying the "duality of genders and their complementarity are not social inventions but originate from God."

Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis acknowledged the church's position but said, "We are discussing the decisions of the Greek state, unrelated to theological beliefs."

Civil unions may be in some Orthodox countries' near future, said George Demacopoulos, director of the Orthodox Christian Studies Centre at Fordham University in New York.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1370 – Northern Crusades: Grand Duchy of Lithuania and the Teutonic Knights meet in the Battle of Rudau.
1616 – Nurhaci proclaims himself Khan of the Later Jin, precursor to the Qing Dynasty.
1621 – Myles Standish is appointed as first military commander of the English Plymouth Colony in North America.
1814 – War of the Sixth Coalition: The Battle of Mormant.
1819 – The United States House of Representatives passes the Missouri Compromise for the first time.
1854 – The United Kingdom recognizes the independence of the Orange Free State.
1863 – A group of citizens of Geneva found an International Committee for Relief to the Wounded, which later became known as the International Committee of the Red Cross.

JUDGES THANKED FOR VERDICT ON LALITA NIWAS LAND CASE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has congratulated all the Nepali people saying that the Special Court has given a historic decision in the Lalita Niwas land embezzlement case.

DPM Shrestha also thanked the special court and judges.

On Thursday, the Special Court ruled that the land of Lalita Niwas belonging to individuals and organisations would now be of the government.

The Special Court has convicted more than 80 persons, including the former Chief Commissioner Deep Basnyat and former Secretary Chhabiraj Panta of the Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority and sentenced them to imprisonment with fines.

DPM Shrestha called the decision of the court historic.

"Finally, the government land of Lalita Niwas has come in the name of the government. "Congratulations to all the Nepali people," Home Minister Shrestha mentioned while posting a status on a social network site on Friday.

"The Special Court made a historic decision in favour of truth and justice against the act and process of looting the state through forgery, fraud and corruption. My earnest gratitude and thanks to the judges of the court," he wrote.



PHOTO: RSS

People of Gurung community clad in traditional attire participating in a rally organised to celebrate the establishment day of Gandaki Province Government in Pokhara on Friday.

NC'S CC PASSES DOCUMENTS FOR MAHASAMITI MEETING

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

The central committee meeting of Nepali Congress has passed various documents to be presented in the upcoming mahasamiti meeting. The mahasamiti meeting is being held in the federal capital from February 19 to 22.

In the central committee meeting, party Vice President Purna Bahadur Khadka presented a policy proposal, while General Secretary Gagan Kumar Thapa an organizational proposal, General Secretary Bishwo Prakash Sharma a contemporary political proposal, spokesperson Dr Prakash Sharan Mahat a report on economic status, potential and future course, and account committee coordinator Shyam Kumar Ghimie an audit report.

The central committee meeting held on February 15 and 16 discussed all these proposals and incorporated the suggestions. These documents are passed with revision so that they would be presented in the mahasamiti meeting, according to chief secretary at NC party office, Krishna Prasad Poudel.

Budget ceiling...

Budget has not been cut

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat clarified that the Ministry of Finance could not reduce the budget endorsed by the Parliament.

On February 12, the government has only revised the half-yearly budget for the current fiscal year 2023/24 and reduced the revenue and expenditure estimates, he said.

Publishing the half-yearly evaluation report, the Ministry of Finance had announced a revised target of Rs. 1,530.26 billion. The government had presented a budget of Rs. 1,751.31 billion for the current fiscal year in May 2023.

He said that according to the provisions of the Economic Procedures and Financial Responsibility Act, the Ministry of Finance has published the half-yearly evaluation report of the budget.

The Ministry of Finance alone cannot amend the budget passed by the Parliament, he informed, adding that it was only estimated that the expenditure and income targets would not be met.

Finance Minister Dr. Mahat said, "I want the expenditure to be more than what we have estimated. Collect more revenue than we expected. The Ministry is working to maximum implementation of budget."

Every ministries and agencies are responsible for implementing the budget from their respective sides, he said.

Clarifying that there were no disputes between the Prime Minister and Finance Minister, he said that the Ministry of Finance was working at the instruction of the Prime Minister to make the country prosperous.

"It is natural for the Prime Minister to have different opinions on some issues. During the discussion, we have different ideas and thoughts, Dr. Mahat said, "However, the Ministry of Finance is working on the basis of the discussions with the Prime Minister and the instructions of the Prime Minister."

Report on Balkumari incident...

Dakshinkali, and the National Investigation District Office Lalitpur, and the test reports were prepared for physical evidence recovered from the incident site.

Police communication details and CCTV footage were also taken from Valley Police Office operational room and the Police Headquarters, Naxal.

The statement also mentioned that the footage taken from the CCTV and the information received in the e-mail of the Commission were thoroughly studied and analysed.

The Commission has expressed its gratitude to all those who assisted in the investigation of the incident.

Meanwhile, talking to The Rising Nepal daily, a source at the Ministry said that the report of the Commission concluded that the death of two persons resulted due to the weakness on the part of Minister for Physical, Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala.

It is said that the minister reached the incident site without getting information about the security situation. "He did not seem to want to take moral responsibility for the incident," said the source.

The commission has recommended that Minister Jwala should take moral responsibility. The Commission is of the view that the incident took place after the vehicle entered the opposite direction on the instruction of Minister Jwala.

Although the Commission found the main fault of the minister, it has also pointed out some weaknesses of the two suspended police officers.

Commission sources also said that departmental actions have been recommended to DSP Umesh Lamsal, field officer, and PSO Bodhraj Danuwar of Minister Jwala.

Minister Jwala inspects Postal...

Stating that mutual coordination and cooperation among the three levels of government was necessary for the timely completion of development works, he suggested that development works should be taken as a common concern.

Minister Jwala inspected the Postal Road at various places in Banke and Bardiya districts. He also inspected the Paraspur-Gaughat road section.

About 57 per cent of progress has been made in the Nepalgunj-Gulariya road section in a year, but the construction works of the Paraspur-Gaughat road have been delayed.

Minister Jwala urged the contractor to continue the work on the Nepalgunj-Gularia section stating that budget was demanded from the Ministry of Finance.

Lila Bahadur Bhandari, chief of the Postal Highway Directorate Planning Office, Nepalgunj said, " Sharma and Company had started the work from February 8, 2023, to complete the work at Rs. 2.78 billion excluding value-added tax."

Project Chief Bhandari said, "Inability to pay the contractors has emerged as a big problem."

Khajura Rural Municipality Chairperson Dambar BK drew the attention of Minister Jwala to complete the construction of a 1,800-meter four-lane road at Khajura Bazaar which started six years ago and construct a bridge over the Pedari Nallah.

Ramesh Sharma, Managing Director of Sharma and Company, said that Rs. 440 million is yet to be paid for the work done.

Sharma said, "If the money is released on time, the work will be completed within the next year and at least 20 kilometres of the road will be blacktopped this year."

Of the 27.62 km long road, 11.6 km is being made four-lane.

Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny dies in prison

AFP
MOSCOW, Feb. 16

Russian opposition leader Alexei Navalny died Friday at the Arctic prison colony where he was serving a 19-year-term, Russia's federal penitentiary service said.

Navalny lost consciousness after going for a walk and could not be revived by medics, the prison service said.

"Navalny felt bad after a walk, almost immediately losing consciousness.

Medical staff arrived immediately and an ambulance team was called," it said.

"Resuscitation measures were carried out which did not yield positive results. Paramedics confirmed the death of the convict. The causes of death are being established."

Russia's Investigative Committee said it had opened an investigation into his death. Navalny's press secretary Kira Yarmysh said his team had not been informed of his death.

"Alexei's lawyer is now flying to Kharp," where his prison colony is, she said in a post on social media.



Citing his spokesman, Russian news agencies reported that President Vladimir Putin had been informed of Navalny's death. Navalny, 47, Russia's most prominent opposition leader, won a huge following with his criticism of corruption in Vladimir Putin's Russia.

His exposes, posted on his YouTube channel racked up millions of views and brought tens of thousands of Russians to the streets, despite Russia's harsh anti-protests laws.

He was jailed in early 2021 after returning to Russia from Germany, where he was recuperating from a near-fatal poisoning attack with Novichok, a Soviet-era nerve agent.

In a string of cases he was sentenced to 19 years in prison on charges widely condemned by independent rights groups and in the West as retribution for his opposition to the Kremlin.

Late last year he was moved to a remove Arctic prison colony in Russia's Yamalo-Nenets region in northern Siberia.

The last post on Navalny's Telegram channel, which he managed through his lawyers and team in exile, was a tribute to his wife, Yulia Navalnaya, posted on Valentine's Day.

Eight Indians, two Nepalis held for taking hostage



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

Police have arrested 10 persons, including eight Indian nationals and two Nepalis on the charge of holding 11 Indian citizens hostage in Kathmandu.

The District Police Range, Kathmandu, which rescued 11 Indian citizens from a house in Gaushala on Wednesday night, arrested eight Indians and two Nepali citizens on the charge of holding them hostage.

"The gang members falsely promised to facilitate their journey to the US," Senior Superintendent of Police and Chief of Kathmandu Police Range Bhupendra Khatri said at a press conference organised to make the arrested individuals public on Thursday.

After receiving information that some Indians were illegally holding the Indian citizens hostage in a house in Gaushala, a joint team of District Police Range and Police Circle Gaushala entered the house and searched the house.

After the operation, the police rescued Gurvinder Singh, Subhash Kuwar, Bhupendra Singh, Pratik, Manveer Singh, Jagdeep Singh, Gurpreet Singh of Mehtabpur, Hoshiarpur district of Punjab, Kuldeep Singh, Rakesh Kumar, and Ashish Kumar and Gurpreet Singh of Rajpura of Punjab,

The arrested two Nepalis included Mohammad Savir Mian of Biratnagar Metropolitan City-5, Morang and Laxman Giri of Phikkal Rural Municipality of Sindhuli, and currently residing in Makalbari, Kathmandu.

Police informed that the passports of the victims, currencies of different countries, fake boarding passes of different airlines, laptops, fake rubber stamps, scissors and paper cutters were also recovered from them. According to the police, two pipes used to torture the captives physically were also recovered.

According to SSP Khatri, the police office has taken a remand order against them to begin further investigation under the kidnapping and body hostage crimes under the National Civil (Code) Act 2017.

MADHES CM YADAV SEEKING VOTE OF CONFIDENCE ON SUNDAY

BY LAXMI CHAUDHARI
Jankpurdham, Feb. 16

Saroj Kumar Yadav, Chief Minister of Madhes Province, is seeking the vote of confidence for the third time in a year after the Janamat Party quit the government and withdrew its support given to his government.

Chief Minister Yadav will seek the vote of confidence for the third time on Sunday after the Janamat Party withdrew support on January 23.

A meeting of the Provincial Assembly has also been called for 2 pm on Sunday.

Chief Minister Yadav has decided to show his majority in the Provincial Assembly after the meeting of the ruling parties concluded in the centre, according to the office of the Chief Minister and the Council of Ministers.

Earlier, the Chief Minister took the vote of confidence for the second time on June 13 last year after the CPN-UML Party withdrew their support to the government on May 15, 2023.

Article 188 (2) of the Constitution of Nepal, 2072, states that the Chief Minister can call a meeting of the Provincial Assembly at any time within 30 days to seek a vote of confidence after a party or parties withdraw their support.

Madhes province government needs the support of 54 members out of 107 Provincial Assembly members.

In the Madhes Provincial Assembly, the CPN-UML has 23 seats, the Nepali Congress 22 and Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal has 18 seats.

Brazil's health agents scour junkyards...

Health workers like Gomes, equipped with masks and plastic gloves, meticulously combed the junkyard on a hot morning, gently kicking and shaking piled up auto parts looking for any trace of the Aedes aegypti mosquito that can spread dengue.

Whenever he saw standing water Gomes grabbed a hand pipette out of his bag and looked for larvae, which he collected in a white plastic container. Captured mosquitos and larvae are kept alive and brought to a city laboratory to be tested for dengue.

At locations with positive tests, health agents spray the walls with a product that kills mosquitos and then monitor the location for weeks.

Maciel, from the Health Ministry, said the first warning about a possible epidemic came in September.

Brazil's leading research institute, the state-funded Oswaldo Cruz Foundation, or Fiocruz, came up with several scenarios indicating that Brazil could have as many as 4.2 million cases this year, up from 1.6 million in 2023.

Maciel said the surge is due to excessive heat and intense rain, both possible effects of climate change or El Niño, a natural, temporary and occasional warming of part of the Pacific that shifts weather patterns across the globe.

Maciel also cited the circulation of four dengue virus serotypes at the same time, one of which authorities had not seen in 15 years.

In Rio, more than 80% of mosquito breeding sites are located in residential properties, health officials say. So, efforts to combat dengue must start in homes, and raising awareness is key, said Mário Sérgio Ribeiro, a health surveillance official for Rio de Janeiro state.

State officials launched a "10 minutes that save lives" initiative to encourage residents to inspect their homes, offices and places of worship for any standing water.

Health workers and volunteers went door to door, pacing up and down the narrow streets of Rio's Tabajara working-class neighborhood, or favela, to spread the word. They distributed leaflets and climbed on rooftops, looking for containers with rainwater.

One elderly woman, Vilza da Costa, told the AP she believes she contracted the disease.

"It started with a fever, then my body was itching all over, weakness, and a lot of pain. I was in a very bad way," she said. "There are a lot of mosquitoes here."

During Carnival, which ended Wednesday, health employees welcomed visitors with free repellent. A van with a giant crossed off mosquito and the words "Against Dengue Everyday" opened and closed the parades several nights, for millions of TV viewers to see.

Maciel said the effect of Carnival will not be known for another week. Even though dengue is not transmissible from person to person, increased tourism can boost the spread of the disease to locations that had not been affected.

It's not clear if the cases have reached a peak and now "are going to start going down, or if the worst-case scenario is indeed happening," Maciel said.

Lopez returns to her pop music

AP
New York, Feb. 16

On "This Is Me....Now," Jennifer Lopez's first solo album in a decade, the singer takes back her rightful place on the throne of pop music.

In 2002, Jennifer Lopez dropped "This Is Me... Then," her third studio album that married her glossy-eyed romanticism with R&B-pop rhythms. She also announced an engagement to the actor Ben Affleck, who she met while filming the movie "Gigli" in 2001. The pair broke up a few years later.

Fast forward 20 years and "Bennifer" — as they were dubbed by the '00s press — has returned, and so has her sublime pop. In 2022, they married, and now in 2024, the "This Is Me" series continues — articulating nostalgia and a loving feeling she knows best. It is the soundtrack to a new J.Lo Renaissance — one where she got her happy ending and has made the art to let listeners into her dreamy love story.

The opening track, "This Is Me... Now," is quintessential J.Lo, with romantic instrumentation of flutes and harps. "Had a lot to learn, had a lot to grow, had to find my way," sings Lopez on a track reminiscent of a track that might've been on her 2002 R&B dance-pop album — with a new, refined wisdom.

It proceeds "To Be Yours," an energetic love song — sentimental but never saccharine — perfect for a serenade or the dance floor atop hip-hop beats.

The album releases Friday, the same day as a film by the same name: "This Is Me... Now: A Love Story."

"Can't Get Enough," an early single that doubled as a tease for the movie, was released with a music video that depicts the singer getting married three times, as she did in real life. In that way, the visual communicates that she's ready to open the door to her life and show it all — the good and the ugly — all the while sweetly singing "I'm still in love with you, boy," a gender-flipped take on Alton Ellis' 1967 reggae classic "I'm Still in Love with You," which her song samples.

As for that relationship transparency: "Dear Ben pt. II" is a sequel to the slow-burn "Dear Ben" from the 2002 album. The second installment is a more dynamic take on the same relationship. "When I think you'll let me down, you lift my hopes," she sings about finding love with Affleck again, two decades later.

At the end of the album is the R&B anthem "Greatest Love Story Never Told" — a bow on the album's full package — Lopez's breathy vocals sway above an acoustic guitar, piano and strings. "It's destiny how we found each other twice in one lifetime," she sings both for her audience and for her husband.



Taplejungko Shiraiima Seto Juhar' released



BY OUR CORRESPONDEN
Taplejung, Feb. 16

A documentary music video titled 'Taplejungko Shiraiima Seto Juhar', featuring renowned Nepali artist Milan Newar and singer Birendra Shrestha, has been released at Phungling, the district headquarters of Taplejung .

The musical documentary aims to unveil the essence of tourism, cultural heritage and identity of Taplejung.

The music for the song has been composed by Shankar Thapa (Smile), with lyrics penned by Tank Bahadur Bhattarai, a writer and the deputy Chief District Officer of Taplejung.

Bhattarai's lyrics beautifully capture the ethnic diversity, cultural richness and authenticity of Taplejung, mentioning the name of beautiful locations such as Kangchenjunga, Kumbhakarna, Sinjema Lake, Olangchung Gola, Timbung Pokhari, Phungphunge waterfall and more.

The documentary vividly captures these tourist attractions and cultural touches as depicted in the song's lyrics.

The video features models Dinesh Lingkhim, Preeti Thalang, Prince Limbu, Vanem Kumar and others adorned in traditional costumes, highlighting the cultural essence of Taplejung.

Notably, distinguished figures like the House of Representatives Member Liladevi Bokhim and former minister Bal Bahadur Samsohang make appearances as guests in the musical documentary.

The production coordination is led by Harkaraj Gurung, while cinematography and editing are handled by Keshav Adhikari and Prakash Basnet, respectively.

MENUKA PERFORMING IN VARIOUS CITIES



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

Menuka Poudel is set to embark on her first live music tour starting from Kathmandu. Organised by MyPay Events, the tour spans four major cities including Kathmandu, Chitwan, Pokhara and Itahari from March 1 to March 29.

According to a press release issued by MyPay, Poudel is performing in Kathmandu on March 1, in Chitwan on March 15, in Pokhara on March 16, and in Itahari on March 29. Hailing from Haldibari 4, in Jhapa, Poudel rose high in her singing career after participating in the Indian Idol recently.

She first exposed her talent in the first season of Nepal Idol at the age of 18. Her talent captured the hearts of Nepalis both at home and abroad.

Subsequently, she showcased her musical skills on international platforms, including India's popular singing reality show 'Sa Re Ga Ma Pa' and the esteemed Indian Idol, in which she secured the top 10 position.

The tour will kick off at 7 pm at Club Platinum in Kathmandu on March 1, as announced by the organisers.

Kristen eager for family but scared of childbirth

AGENCIES
London, Feb. 16

Kristen Stewart is eagerly anticipating motherhood with her fiancée Dylan Meyer, but she confesses to feeling "scared" about childbirth.

The former 'Twilight' star, aged 33, and her partner, a 36-year-old screenwriter and actress, whom she became engaged to in 2021, are beginning "preparations for how they might go about getting pregnant." According to Rolling Stone, the couple has "discussed the possibility of carrying each other's embryos."

Kristen shared with the magazine about their plans for having a baby: "I don't know what my family's going to look like, but there's no way that I don't start acquiring kids. And also, ideally at some point soon I go, 'I want to have a kid.' I really want that to happen."

While Kristen has no qualms about being pregnant, the prospect of childbirth terrifies her. She likened it to being on a significant trip, saying: "I'm not scared of being pregnant. I'm not scared of having a kid. But I'm so scared of childbirth, it's crazy. Have you ever been too on drugs where you've suddenly needed to be on your hands and knees? I hate that. I mean, I smoke a lot of weed - I obviously self-medicate—but I don't like hard drugs. And I've tried—a lot. I just can't deal."

Zendaya stuns at 'Dune: Part Two' world premiere

AP
London, Feb. 16

Zendaya is on a fashion roll, in a cyborg "Dune: Part Two" kind of way.

The co-star of the highly anticipated film sequel stunned Thursday at its world premiere when she hit the sand-strewn carpet in a silver robot suit straight from the archive of Mugler. It's from the French fashion house's fall/winter 1995 "Cirque d'hiver" 20th anniversary collection, according to a company statement.

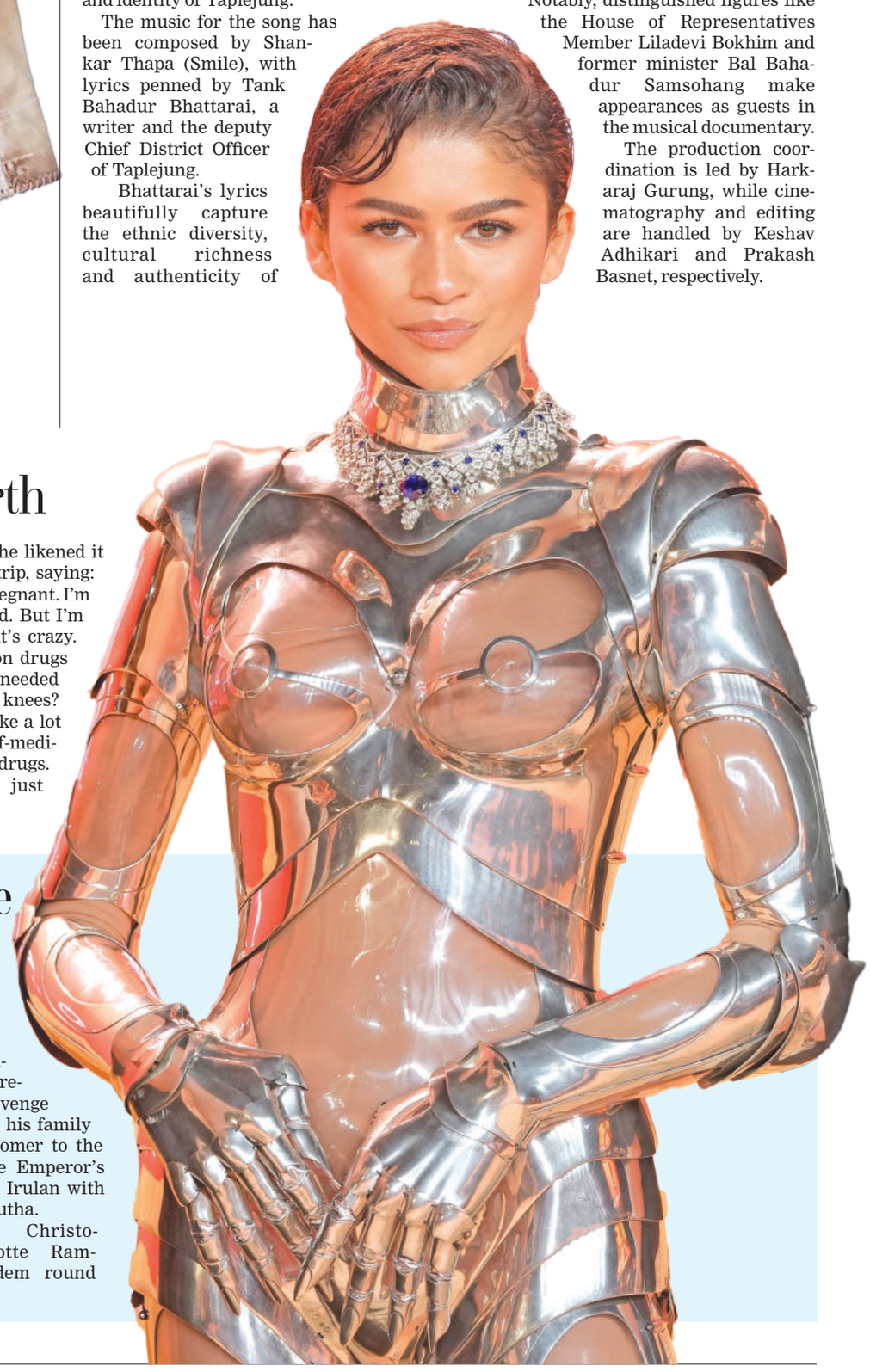
That translates to "Winter Circus," not unlike the fanfare surrounding the March 1 release of Denis Villeneuve's second half of his sci-fi epic.

Zendaya's body-hugging armor outfit with sheer plexiglass inserts has built-in gloves she paired with matching silver heels. Mugler gave special thanks to her stylist, Law Roach, in an email detailing the vintage look. While the runway version included a matching headpiece, Zendaya opted for a short sleek hairdo and a blue diamond necklace from Bulgari.

She was joined on the carpet by fellow stars Timothée Chalamet, Josh Brolin and Rebecca Ferguson, along with new cast members Austin Butler, Florence Pugh and Villeneuve.

The new film picks up where 2021's "Dune" left off. Chalamet's Paul Atreides unites with Zendaya's Chani and the Fremen in order to seek revenge against those who killed his family members. Pugh, a newcomer to the world of "Dune" as the Emperor's daughter, plays Princess Irulan with Austin Butler as Feyd-Rautha.

Stellan Skarsgard, Christopher Walken, Charlotte Rampling and Javier Bardem round out the cast.



HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You may currently feel pressured by your friends to do something you don't want to do. As the sensitive Moon in your communication zone defers to heavy Saturn in your 12th House of Secrets.

TAURUS: Your magnetism can bring you rewards today. As appealing Venus unites with potent Pluto in your 10th House of Authority, you can attract positive attention from someone with the power to help you achieve your goals.

GEMINI: Your curiosity can lead you on an exciting adventure right now. When fun-loving Venus meets intense Pluto in your thoughtful 9th house, a quick online search regarding an interesting tidbit.

CANCER: An enticing financial opportunity could appear before you at any moment. As lavish Venus and powerful Pluto meet in your 8th House of Big Money, investing your resources might seem like a way to rapidly increase them.

LEO: A recent relationship could be developing more quickly than you find comfortable. While social Venus entwines with overbearing Pluto in your partnership zone.

VIRGO: Doing a chore just right could seem crucial to you now. That said, as the expressive Moon in your authority zone clashes with uptight Saturn in your partnership sector.

LIBRA: Your desire for pleasure could take on urgency at the moment. Although you might feel obligated to push it aside and devote your attention to your responsibilities instead.

SCORPIO: Improving your home environment may be an urgent priority. With aesthetic Venus and insightful Pluto united in your domestic zone, you're attuned to what would look good.

SAGITTARIUS: Getting your own way could currently seem essential. As sentimental Venus and pushy Pluto conspire in your 3rd House of Communication, you're equipped to sweet-talk someone else.

CAPRICORN: Money matters could be going well for you at this time. However, you can't count on the people around you to agree with your interpretation of the facts.

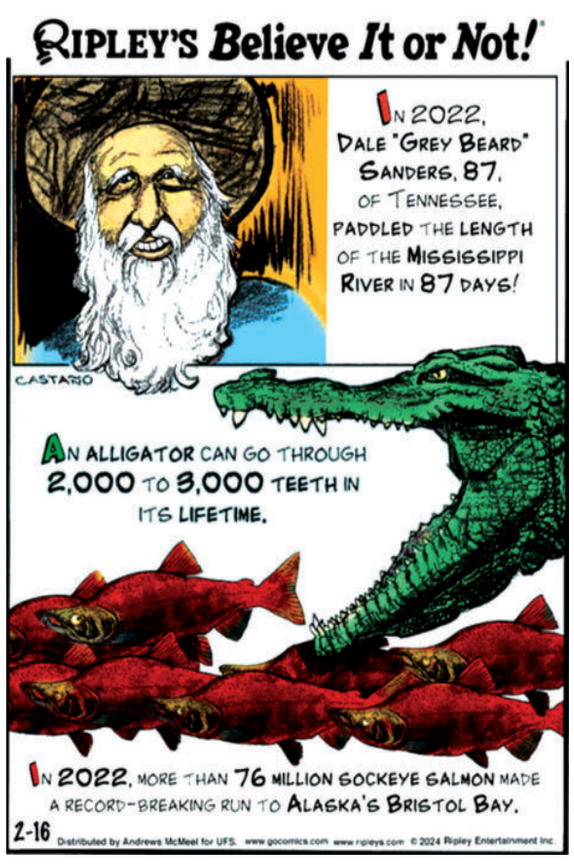
AQUARIUS: You're equipped to cast an impressive presence now. As alluring Venus and mysterious Pluto blend energies in your sign, others are probably more than a little curious about what you have to offer.

PISCES: Your fantasy life could be on a roll at the moment, but daydreaming isn't just for frivolous fun! When relational Venus and perceptive Pluto come together in your 12th House of the Subconscious.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





ACC Women's Premier Cup

Malaysia's Elsa hunts down Nepal in semifinal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 16

Nepal needed to defend 11 runs in the final over to progress to the ACC Women's Premier Cup 2024 finals. However, Malaysia's Elsa Hunter stayed at the crease and chased the target successfully with a tired body to knock Nepal out of the campaign.

Electing to bat first, Nepal's batters struggled to score enough runs against the tournament host Malaysia. Losing six wickets, Nepal posted a target of 116 runs at the end of 20 overs.

Captain Indu Barma (29 off 37) was the highest scorer for the team followed by Dolly Bhatta (25 off 14), Kabita Kunwar (23 off 31) and Rubina Chhetry (20 off 18).

Nepal lost Kabita Kunwar and Kabita Joshi (2 off 7) to run-outs alongside Dolly, who gave away her wicket while running for the second in the final over of the first inning. Sita Rana Magar was only able to contribute 6 runs for the team before getting struck leg before.

Mahirah Izzati Ismail and Captain Winifred Duraisingam took two and one wickets respectively for Malaysia.

Nepal was still motivated despite defending a paltry target as three wickets of Malaysia fell by the 9th over. Winifred (2 off 8), Ainna Hamizah Hashim (0 off 4) and Mas Elysa (13 off 22) returned to the pavilion without contributing adequately.

On the other hand, three wickets in 8.4 overs with Malaysia at 36/3 kept Nepal's hopes for the finals alive. Nevertheless, Elsa Hunter, who came in at three, stood as the wall to prevent Nepal from advancing.

Entering the crease after Ainna was struck leg before in the second over, Elsa continued her hunt for the runs and won the match for Malaysia in the second-to-last ball of the 20th over.

Elsa was tired after she entered the 30s. Stealing runs with a weary body; she took a couple of seconds to take a deep breath before facing another delivery several times.

However, despite it being hard for her body, Hunter did not break down and registered her half-century. She continued hitting boundaries and running for single and doubles to keep the required run rate in check.

The Nepali team did not see a chance to win the match until Elsa was hunting. Welcoming Kabita Kunwar in the final over with a four, Elsa hit the third ball of the over for another four. With three runs remaining in three balls, Player of the match Elsa ran for a double in the fourth ball and took Malaysia to the finals of the ACC Women's Premier Cup with a single in the fifth ball.

She stayed not out at 69 runs off 53 deliveries with six fours.

Sita and Kabita Joshi bagged two wickets each while Rubina and Kabita Kunwar claimed one each for Nepal as Malaysia lost six wickets in the chase.

Losing to Malaysia in the semis, Nepal also lost its chance to qualify for the Women's T20 Asia Cup as two finalists in the Premier Cup qualify for the major Asian tournament in women's cricket.

Malaysia will now face the UAE in the finals on February 18. The UAE defeated Thailand in another semi-final match by four runs. Nepal, Malaysia, UAE and Thailand had reached the semis without losing a single match in the campaign.



PHOTO: ACC

NZ wins South Africa Test series for first time



AP
Hamilton, Feb. 16

Kane Williamson made 133 in an unbroken partnership of 152 with Will Young to lead New Zealand to a seven-wicket win over South Africa on the fourth day of the second test Friday and to its first-ever series win over the Proteas.

Williamson scored centuries in both innings of the first test which New Zealand won by 281 runs.

South Africa took a 31-run first innings lead in the second test and extended that to 267 when it made 235 in its second innings.

New Zealand reached 40-1 before stumps on day three, setting up a fourth day on which it needed a further 227 while South Africa needed nine wickets to win the match and save the series.

New Zealand's total of 269-3 was its fifth-highest in a successful fourth-innings run chase.

The South Africa team is considerably under-strength as most of its leading players remained at home to play in a domestic Twenty20 league. Six Proteas players including captain Neil Brand made their debuts in the first test and the second test lineup had only 51 tests in total compared to New Zealand's 436.

The South Africa bowlers made New Zealand grind its way to a victory. The winning runs finally came in the 95th over, about 20 minutes before the end of play on day four.

Williamson's played almost a lone hand at first as he built his 32nd test century from 203 deliveries. He put on 64 for the third wicket with Rachin Ravindra who made 20 from 72 balls.

He then found a resolute partner in Young who stayed with him and was 60 not out at the close. New Zealand was under pressure when Young came out to join Williamson at the fall of Ravindra's wicket, still needing 150 to win. Runs came slowly for him at first as Williamson approached his century but then more freely and he reached his 50 from 118 balls.

Williamson is one of only two active players along with Australia's Steve Smith to reach 32 centuries and has done so faster, in 172 innings, than Smith, Ricky Ponting, Sachin Tendulkar, Younis Khan, Sunil Gavaskar, Kumar Sangakarra, Jacques Kallis or Brian Lara, among others.

Williamson is the No. 1-ranked batter in tests and showed why with three centuries in four innings in the series and a total of 403 runs at an average of 134. He batted almost 18-1/2 hours in total in the series.

"Coming into today on a wearing surface we knew we were going to have to string partnerships together," Williamson said. "Credit to South Africa. Certainly for the first couple of days they outplayed us I thought.

"We had to fight hard to get out of that position and change momentum and with the partnerships and seeing off the new ball were able to give ourselves the chance."

SNIPPETS

Nepal A and Canada XI playing three ODIs

Kathmandu (TRN): Losing all matches to Nepal's senior cricket team in a 3 ODI bilateral series, Canada's senior team is staying in Nepal for another series of 3 ODIs, this time with Nepal's newly formed A team. According to the Cricket Association of Nepal, Nepal A and Canada will be facing each other at the Mulpani International Cricket Ground on February 18, 20 and 22. The CAN, on February 14, made public the A team of Nepal comprising talented U19 players, inactive internationals and good performers at the PM Men's Cup 2024. The team is being captained by Binod Bhandari with former player Gyanendra Malla and Kalam Ali as the coaches.

Gaurika improves her national record

Kathmandu (TRN): Swimmer Gaurika Singh broke the national record in the women's 50m backstroke event at the World Aquatics Championship held in Doha, Qatar on Friday. Her new record stands at 30.80 seconds, surpassing her previous record of 31.44 seconds set in the 2023 World Aquatics Championship held in Fukuoka, Japan. This was her second national record set in Doha as she also set a new record of 1 minute and 5.47 seconds in the 100m backstroke event. Alexander Shah, another Nepali swimmer, also improved upon his old national record in the men's 100m freestyle, setting a new mark of 52.17 seconds, bettering his previous record of 52.94 seconds set in Fukuoka, Japan.

Women's fbl team bade farewell

Kathmandu (TRN): The All Nepal Football Association (ANFA) bade farewell to the women's football team leaving to participate in the WAFF Championship in Saudi Arabia. Nepal, an invited team to West Asia, is in the group with Palestine, Syria and Iraq. The other four teams in another group are Jordan, Saudi Arabia, Guam and Lebanon. The tournament kicks off on February 19 with two matches – Guam vs Lebanon and Saudi Arabia vs Jordan. Nepal is facing Syria in its first group match on February 20. Likewise, Nepal will face Iraq and Palestine on February 22 and 24 respectively. Head coach Rajendra Tamang and captain Anjila Tumbapo Subba shared a positive mentality as the team headed towards Saudi for the tournament. Meanwhile, Makwanpur District Football Association has assured to provide Rs. 100,000 to the women's team to motivate them.

15s Rugby tourney from Feb. 18

Kathmandu (TRN): The 15s Rugby Championship-2080 is going to take place in Kathmandu from February 18. The Nepal Rugby Association has announced that all preparations for the six-day-long tournament have been completed. The tournament will be held for three days, on Sunday, Wednesday and Saturday. The competition will be held in a league format this year, with four clubs competing for a title worth Rs. 100,000. The clubs include the Gorkhali Rugby Club, Nepal Police Club, Tribhuvan Army Club and Nepal APF Club. The championship will kick off with a match between Gorkhali and Police Club at the Dasharath Stadium on Sunday, followed by the second match of the inaugural day between Army and APF. General Secretary of the association Gobinda Ghimire also revealed that the participating teams began training a month ago.

Duckett ton leads England counter, Ashwin takes 500th wicket

AP
Rakot, Feb. 16

Replying to India's seemingly daunting 445 all out, England opener Ben Duckett smashed an undefeated 133 to leave the tourists on 207-2 at stumps on Day 2 of the third cricket test, which saw spinner Ravichandran Ashwin become only the second Indian bowler to take 500 test wickets.

England still trails India by 238 runs. Ashwin followed compatriot Anil Kumble (619 wickets) as the spinner took his landmark wicket in the final session Friday.

He had Zak Crawley (15) caught at fine leg and became the second quickest bowler to reach the milestone in 98 tests. Sri Lanka's Muttiah Muralitharan is the fastest to 500 wickets in 87 tests. Kumble had reached it in 105 tests.

Duckett needed only 88 balls for his third test century for England, and his 118-delivery innings so far included two sixes and 21 fours with England scoring at an average of almost six runs an over, compared to 3.40 for India's innings. Joe Root (9 not out) is also at the crease.



Ollie Pope (39) was the other English batter out, trapped leg before by Mohammed Siraj (1-54).

Earlier Friday, resuming its first innings on 326-5, India lost Kuldeep Yadav in the fourth over of the morning, caught behind off James Anderson for four.

The bigger blow came six balls later — century-maker Ravindra Jadeja offered a simple return catch to Root.

Jadeja was out for 112 runs, adding only two more runs to his total on the first day. Overall, he had faced 225 deliveries and hit nine fours as well as a six for his second test hundred at his home ground.

After the drinks' break, there was an incident involving Ashwin. He was penalized by umpire Joel Wilson for repeatedly running onto the danger area of the pitch, and England was awarded five penalty runs. It started its first innings from 5-0.

On Thursday's opening day, centuries by Rohit Sharma and Jadeja helped India reach 326-5 after the home side won the toss and after a poor start. India was 33-3 but Sharma and Jadeja rebuilt the innings with a 204-run stand. The five-match series is level at 1-1. India won the second test by 106 runs after England beat the hosts by 28 runs in the opener.

Loftus-Cheek lifts Milan past Rennes in Europa League

AP
London, Feb. 16

Ruben Loftus-Cheek scored two goals as AC Milan eased to 3-0 victory over Rennes in the first leg of the playoff for the Europa League's round of 16 on Thursday.

The former Chelsea midfielder headed in the opener in the 32nd minute in front of over 69,000 spectators at the San Siro, with the ball bouncing in off the post.

He doubled the advantage by heading in the rebound from close range following a corner three minutes after halftime, before Rafael Leão finished the scoring for the dominant hosts.



Loftus-Cheek has now scored five goals in his last five games for Milan, a seven-time European Cup champion that has never won the second-tier Europa League or its predecessor, the UEFA Cup. In the early kickoffs, Romelu Lukaku also kept up his hot scoring form by netting the equalizer to give Roma a 1-1 draw at Feyenoord.

Brazilian winger Igor Paixão put the hosts ahead with a header in the first-half injury time before Lukaku nodded home in the 67th after a meeting a cross into the box.

It was Lukaku's sixth goal of this season's Europa League and he now has 21 in his last 18 games in the competition.

It is the third time in three years that the two teams are playing each other in Europe, including the 2022 Europa Conference League final which Roma won 1-0 to give Jose Mourinho another major trophy. The eight runners-up in the Europa League group stage are playing the eight third-place teams from the Champions League group stage in the playoffs.

The return matches are scheduled for Feb. 22. The eight winners will then take on the Europa League's group winners, who qualified directly for the round of 16. They include Liverpool, West Ham and Brighton from the Premier League, as well Leverkusen, Atalanta, Villarreal, Rangers and Slavia Prague.

In a tense finish in Hamburg, Marseille substitute Iliman Ndiaye's 90th-minute goal put his team ahead 2-1 ahead before Shakhtar Donetsk's Eguinaldo salvaged a 2-2 draw in a game played in Germany due to Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:40 am, Sunset at 5:56 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly regions of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 21 - 23°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	26.7	7.8	0.0
Dadeldhura	19.0	5.2	0.0
Dhangadi	27.5	10.8	0.0
Birendranagar	25.8	8.4	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.8	11.0	0.0
Jumla	19.3	-2.4	0.0
Ghorahi	25.0	10.7	0.0
Pokhara	242.0	10.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	25.4	12.0	0.0
Simara	26.6	10.5	0.0
Kathmandu	22.7	5.6	0.0
Okhaldhunga	20.5	8.5	0.0
Taplejung	18.3	6.5	0.0
Dhankuta	23.4	10.5	0.0
Biratnagar	26.2	12.5	0.0
Jomsom	14.0	0.5	0.0*
Dharan	27.0	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	18.0	7.0	0.0*
Janakpur	28.4	14.5	0.0*
Jiri	18.6	1.6	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES
February 17, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.53	Rs. 133.13
Euro	1	Rs. 142.77	Rs. 143.42
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 166.89	Rs. 167.64
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 150.41	Rs. 151.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.48	Rs. 86.87
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.31	Rs. 98.76
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.47	Rs. 98.92
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.82	Rs. 8.86
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.42	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.34	Rs. 35.50
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.34	Rs. 36.51
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.68	Rs. 3.69
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.08	Rs. 36.25
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.72	Rs. 27.85
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.94	Rs. 9.99
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.70	Rs. 12.75
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.15	Rs. 19.24
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.94	Rs. 17.02
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.26	Rs. 432.21
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.56	Rs. 353.15

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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